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Be united, Iran leader tells Muslim nations

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Should CJP be a political party?

Success of movement should be judged by participation of youth

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HONOURING A LEGEND

Federer inducted into tennis Hall of Fame

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INSIDE



Russia warns of 'massive strikes' against Ukraine

MOSCOW
Russia's Defence Ministry on Sunday said it was gearing up for large-scale attacks on Ukraine's energy infrastructure in response to strikes by Kyiv on civilian infrastructure and oil and energy complex in Russia. » PAGE 14



Strikes over NRC are not the way, says Manipur CM

GUWAHATI
Manipur Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh said on Sunday that he favoured updating the National Register of Citizens (NRC) in the State, but insisted that blockades were not the way to seek the exercise after civil society groups threatened a 24-hour shutdown. » PAGE 4

T.N. moves SC over Cauvery water backlog

NEW DELHI
The Tamil Nadu government on Sunday approached the Supreme Court seeking a direction to the Karnataka government to release 17,604 tmc ft of water from the Cauvery river, the balance quantity as on August 27, 2026, according to the pro-rata formula. » PAGE 3

India, Uzbekistan elevate strategic relationship

Uzbekistan is at heart of India's engagement in Central Asia, says PM Modi during two-day visit

Two countries plan comprehensive strategic partnership; set \$5 billion trade target by 2030

Two sides agree to establish a framework for supply of Uranium from Uzbekistan to India

Press Trust of India
TASHKENT

India and Uzbekistan on Sunday decided to elevate their ties to a comprehensive strategic partnership and set a target of \$5 billion in annual trade by 2030 following talks between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Uzbek President Shavkat Mirziyoyev. The two sides inked 11 agreements for boosting engagement in several key sectors, including mining and tourism, and agreed to establish a framework for long-term supply of Uranium from Uzbekistan to India in line with cooperation in the civil nuclear energy sector. The talks focused on expanding cooperation in areas of critical minerals, mining, defence and security, agriculture, pharmaceuticals, digital public infrastructure, including

UPI, and education. "We are celebrating the 15th anniversary of our strategic partnership. I am delighted that, on this special occasion, we are elevating our ties to the level of a comprehensive strategic partnership," Mr. Modi said. "We will move forward by setting concrete goals within this framework," he said. Mr. Modi said both sides will also elevate their existing joint commission from the level of secretaries to that of ministerial level. Mr. Mirziyoyev said Uzbekistan is determined to boost ties with India in diverse sectors. "We are aiming to advance cooperation in sectors such as energy, culture, critical minerals, pharmaceuticals, jewelry, and agriculture," the Uzbek President said. The current volume of bilateral trade between the two nations is over \$1



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Uzbekistan President Shavkat Mirziyoyev after receiving the country's highest national award. ANI

billion. "Uzbekistan is at the heart of Central Asia and is at the heart of India's engagement in the region," Mr. Modi said. The Prime Minister added: "A stronger India-Uzbekistan partnership will be a powerful force for peace, progress and prosperity in Central Asia." Delving into the ambitious agenda of future cooperation between the

two sides, Mr. Modi said India and Uzbekistan will encourage their defence industries to look at co-development and co-production of military hardware. A joint statement said the two leaders agreed to expand cooperation in the field of critical minerals through the implementation of joint projects in geological exploration, mining, mineral processing,

and the development of integrated value chains. "The close defence and security cooperation between our two countries reflects our deep mutual trust. In the future, we will promote direct linkages, co-production, and co-development between our defence industries," Mr. Modi said. "We believe that terrorism, extremism, and separatism pose serious challenges to the entire region," Mr. Modi said. "Maintaining a policy of zero tolerance against these threats has been, and will continue to be, our shared resolve." A Letter of Intent for the restoration and conservation of the Buddhist sites of Fayaz Tepa and Kara Tepa in Uzbekistan was also agreed upon. These ancient Buddhist monasteries in southern Uzbekistan highlight how Buddhism spread along the Silk Road

and flourished in Central Asia. **Pact on UPI payments** The two sides announced that a commercial pact was firming up between NPCI International Payments Ltd (NPCI) and Uzbekistan's National Interbank Processing Centre JSC to enable UPI apps of India to scan Uzbekistan's national QR (UZQR) for making merchant payments in the Central Asian nation. The announcements included a grant of \$1 million for afforestation in the Aral Sea region. Mr. Modi landed in Tashkent on Saturday on a two-day visit to bolster ties with Uzbekistan. In his opening remarks at the bilateral talks, the Prime Minister also made a mention of the "productive talks" he had with the Uzbek President over dinner last night. "We had a productive

discussion over dinner last night and took several important decisions." "We will establish a Coordination Council at the level of Foreign Ministers to provide direction to all aspects of our cooperation through close coordination," Mr. Modi said. Amid a complex geopolitical situation, they stressed the need for a free, open and rules-based international order, building on their multilateral cooperation, a joint statement said. "The leaders highly appreciated the progress achieved in regional cooperation and reaffirmed their commitment to further strengthening engagement within Central Asia-India format at the level of Heads of States and other levels," the statement added. **PM VISITS MEMORIAL** » PAGE 4

In deep water



The Sangam area inundated with floodwater from the swollen Ganga and Yamuna rivers in Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh on Sunday. PTI

788 dead, 2,500 missing in Nepal; preservation of bodies presents challenges

Sanjeev Satgainya
KATHMANDU

Four days after the flood in Nepal, the death toll in the disaster touched 788, and 2,502 people remained missing even as the preservation of recovered bodies became a challenge for the authorities who continued with the rescue efforts. Foreign Secretary Amrit Bahadur Rai said Nepal urgently required freezer units and DNA-testing kits, warning that the bodies must be preserved and identified quickly to prevent decomposition and contain public-health risks. He said the government is "putting all our resources at disposal in relief and rescue operations."

"We have requested several countries," he said. "Some other immediate requirements, like airtight bags for storing bodies, have started to arrive and other equipment are expected to arrive soon," he added. More than 900 workers are missing from hydropower sites, and officials believe around 100 people trapped inside tunnels are alive. Mr. Rai said experts from India, China, and South Korea joined the Nepal Army's efforts in rescuing these workers. The Nepal Army said that after floodwaters receded, its rescue teams resumed efforts to locate tunnel entrances using drilling machines, excavators, hydraulic cutters and other heavy equipment.

Mass burials Authorities also began mass burials of unidentified bodies in Chitwan,



Nature's fury: Houses lie partially submerged in slush in Nuwakot district of Nepal. PRABHAT KHANAL

around 200 km from Rasuwa, on Saturday after collecting DNA samples so that the remains can be exhumed if the victims are identified. Madan Lama, an information officer at the District Administration Office in Chitwan, said around 170 bodies had been buried since Saturday, including 96 on the first day, after collecting DNA samples. An Indian forensic team specialising in DNA testing and analysis arrived to support health officials in collecting samples. India's External Affairs Ministry said in New Delhi on Saturday that more than 275 Indians and 128 persons of Indian origin remained missing. On Sunday, it shared a list of 149 people who were rescued. The Nepal Tourism Board said 591 foreign nationals remain missing and 289 have been rescued, including 180 Indian and 89 Chinese nationals. Earlier on Sunday, authorities warned of possible fresh flooding and urged residents in affected districts to remain on high alert as water levels rose in the Bhotekoshi River.

A suspension bridge in central Nepal was swept away on Sunday morning due to a fresh flood in the Trishuli River, according to officials. Prakash Pokharel, a geologist and researcher at the National Disaster Risk Reduction Management Authority, said flood warnings had been sent to people's phones. The flood, triggered by a glacial collapse, left hundreds missing on the Tibet side, where Chinese authorities reported 16 deaths and 546 people unaccounted for. Asked about the status of Nepali citizens in the disaster-hit area of Tibet, Mr. Rai said China has provided a list that will be updated. The disaster had struck on Wednesday when a glacial collapse near the Nepal-China border in Rasuwa district triggered a massive surge of water, mud and debris through the Bhotekoshi and Trishuli river systems. **'WARNING TO INDIA'** » PAGE 8 **DATA POINT** » PAGE 9

'Hindutva's vision of Bharat includes Muslims'

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) chief Mohan Bhagwat on Saturday said that Hindutva does not envisage a Bharat (name he uses for India) without Muslims, asserting that a person who believes Muslims should have no place in the country would cease to be a Hindu. Addressing an event in New York City, where he spoke with leaders from different communities and religions, Mr. Bhagwat said that Muslims, during a dialogue with him, had questioned him about the RSS's vision of a "Hindu Rashtra" and whether Muslims would be driven out of the country. "I said 'no', that is not Hindutva. If any Hindu thinks that there should be no Muslims in Bharat, he will not remain Hindu," he said.

Mr. Bhagwat stressed that while people may follow different religions, humanity remains one. "We live in a society where religions may be different, but humanity is one," he said, adding that India's tradition had been to provide shelter to people irrespective of their religious identity. He also cited the RSS's service activities to underline his claim that the organisation does not discriminate on the basis of religion. According to him, around 1.3 lakh service projects are being run by RSS volunteers with the help of the public. Recalling an incident in Dadri, Haryana, where two aircraft from Muslim-majority countries collided, Mr. Bhagwat said RSS volunteers were among the first to reach the site. As all passengers had died, the volunteers helped arrange funerals and assisted rela-



Faith forum: Mohan Bhagwat attends the 'Universal Oneness celebration' at New York's Madison Square Garden on Saturday. PTI

tives in identifying the victims, he said. **Talks with minorities** "We don't have the thought that they are Muslims," Mr. Bhagwat said, referring to the RSS volunteers' approach to relief and service. He said the organisation's approach was rooted in the belief that "we" and "ours" should replace the narrow focus on "me" and

"mine". "Where there is 'me' and 'mine', there is no solution. 'We' and 'ours' is the solution," he said. Mr. Bhagwat also referred to the RSS's dialogue with members of minority communities, saying that the organisation had begun engaging more extensively with Muslims and Christians in Bharat after 2018. "Dialogue is the first

step, and service is another step," he said. Invoking the example of Ramakrishna Paramahansa, the RSS chief said the spiritual teacher had practised different religious traditions, including Islam and Christianity. He quoted him as saying: "As many ways, as many thoughts. All lead to one way." Mr. Bhagwat said the idea of the unity of humanity was embedded in India's traditional thought as well as in the Constitution. He argued that social change could not be achieved through politics alone and called for initiatives based on selfless service, dialogue and unity. "Things cannot be achieved through politics alone. Sorry to say, but the fact is that politics has now become a game of self-interest. Our experience in India is that we have to start with society, and we have started it," he said.

INBRIEF



AAP leader Gurpreet Singh shot dead in Punjab's Ferozepur

Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) leader Gurpreet Singh alias Gopi, 45, was shot dead by four armed assailants in Ferozepur district, with police on Sunday saying the killing was linked to an election-related dispute. The police said four car-borne assailants got down from their vehicle in the main bazaar of Mamdot on Saturday evening and opened fire at Singh and Harpreet alias Happy, 22. They were rushed to the Civil Hospital where Singh was declared brought dead, while Mr. Harpreet was referred to a private hospital in Ludhiana, the police said. PTI

Bihar boy stages protest over 'police excesses' against parents

A six-year-old boy, who made headlines earlier this week for joining the student protest in Patna, on Sunday initiated a sit-in at Gardanibagh area alleging that his parents were "beaten up by the police while he was taken into custody". The boy had joined the protests led by Bihar Public Service Commission exam aspirants on August 25. During the stir, the protesters intended to gherao Chief Minister Samrat Chaudhury's residence over a range of demands, including a single-tier test for the Teacher Recruitment Examination. "My parents were beaten up while I was kept separated from them in custody for eight hours. My parents are not criminals, so why did police beat them up?" the boy said. PTI

Samruddhi Expressway traffic diverted after gas pipeline leak

Yohaán Varghese
MUMBAI

Traffic was diverted as a precautionary measure along the 24-km stretch of the Samruddhi Expressway after a gas leak was reported from a GAIL pipeline in Maharashtra's Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar district around 5 p.m. on Saturday, officials said.

Traffic was resumed between the Hadas Pimpalgaon and Maliwada areas

Traffic restored between Hadas Pimpalgaon and Maliwada areas at 4 a.m on Sunday

along Samruddhi Highway at 4 a.m. on Sunday, according to district officials.

After the incident was reported near Takliwadi in Gangapur taluka, the district administration launched precautionary

measures and alerted GAIL officials, they said.

Vehicles on the way to Nagpur exited at the Maliwada interchange, using the Dhule-Solapur highway, and re-entered the expressway at Hadas Pimpalgaon, the officials said.

"The administration initiated precautionary steps and called officials from GAIL to the spot. Firefighting teams were also kept on standby," District Collector Vinay Gowda said.

SPOTLIGHT

Amit Bhelari

It has been just six days since the students' protests ended in Ranchi, and Devendra Nath Mahto, 34, is out on a yatra. The student leader went on a hunger strike for 16 days, along with five others, demanding accountability and reforms in the recruitment exam system in Jharkhand.

On August 24, Mahto launched the Bharti Vyavastha Sudhar Yatra (Recruitment System Reform Journey), from Nemra village in Ramgarh district. Nemra is the birthplace of former Chief Minister Shibu Soren, co-founder of the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha that is currently in power in a coalition government in the State.

"My body is weak, but my soul is stronger than anybody else. You just need willpower and the support of the people, which will keep moving you ahead. I never cared about my health during the hunger strike for the students," he tells the crowd at Nemra.

The yatra, across Jharkhand's 24 districts, is to garner public support for transparency and fairness in the recruitment examinations.

Mahto, who hails from Kapdih village in Ranchi district, has two MA degrees, one in Sanskrit, one in Kurmali, both from Dr.

Shyama Prasad Mukherjee University, in Ranchi. He graduated with a B.Ed degree from Vinoba Bhave University in 2017.

He began his protest on July 2, 2026, sitting in dharna at Morabadi ground in Ranchi, under the banner of the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC)-Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC) Abhyarthi Nyay Manch. However, after the police disallowed him, he shifted to the Jaipal Singh Munda Stadium, joining the protest by JPSC-JSSC Reform Manch, led by student leader Ravindra Paswan.

Both wanted the cancellation of JPSC and JSSC exams, a CBI investigation, and also cancellation of all exams conducted by a blacklisted agency. They demanded prosecution of officials, besides the reconstitution of commissions and a complete examination calendar.

Jharkhand CM Hemant Soren called an emergency meeting of the Cabinet on August 17 and agreed to most of the demands made by the students, except the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) probe. The next day, the State government issued a notification cancelling 22 exams over irregularities and handed over 23 additional exams to be investigated by the Crime Investigation Department. The students ended their protest, including the 16-day hunger

Taking reforms to the road

The students' protest in Ranchi over alleged irregularities in recruitment examinations for government jobs remained in the news for most of the month of August. A look into the fallout of the decision by the Jharkhand government led by Chief Minister Hemant Soren to cancel several exams



Devendra Nath Mahto and supporters at the launch of his yatra seeking reforms in recruitment exams at Nemra, birthplace of former CM Shibu Soren in Ramgarh district, Jharkhand. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

strike.

The Supreme Court on August 24, 2026, issued notice to Jharkhand for a CBI probe into the alleged malpractices in the Jharkhand Combined Civil Services Preliminary Examination.

The CBI is still investigating the first and second JPSC examinations, held in 2003 and 2006.

The reforms yatra took

shape after the Jharkhand High Court stayed the State government notification of cancelling recruitment exams, including the JSSC-CGL exam, which hires for mid-level government jobs. After the order, the students who had protested for 26 days, alleging irregularities in recruitment exams, felt cheated by the government.

They allege that to end

their protest the government cancelled intentionally the exams, knowing it would not stand in court.

A trip across Jharkhand

Mahto goes from village to village, stopping for students to gather around him. Children come too, but most of the crowd is between 20 and 25. People line the streets to welcome him, showering him with

flowers, garlanding him. He sometimes hops out of his van barefooted, walking with his supporters, giving little speeches over the public address system.

On the fifth day, he is in Jamtara district. Responding to the crowd, Mahto says, "The enthusiasm and support of the youth make it clear that the fight against job-selling and for transparency and justice in recruitment has now become the voice of every village."

When the yatra passes through Ramgarh district, Santosh Manjhi, a graduate, joins the group. "I am keen on a government job, but repeated paper leaks and irregularities in the exam system have badly affected my morale. We need to bring reform into the competitive exam system. That's only possible when someone makes an attempt with honesty," he says.

Paswan, 30, has a B.Sc. degree from St. Columba's College, Hazaribagh, and B.Ed. and M.Sc. degrees from Vinoba Bhave University, Hazaribagh. He is a resident of Giridih district and has also taken several competitive exams.

He claims that paper leaks in Jharkhand have increased manifold. He points to the JSSC-CGL exam, which was conducted in September 2024, but was cancelled when the paper leaked. He says the re-exam also faced allegations of a paper leak, irreg-

ularities, and cheating, but the Jharkhand High Court intervened, and the results were declared in December 2025.

"The people in Jharkhand know very well that many students were taken to Nepal to memorise the questions and answers in the JSSC-CGL exam," Paswan says, adding a laundry list of other irregularities.

On August 21, his JPSC-JSSC Reform Manch asked its followers to burn the effigy of Hemant Soren in every district. This turned violent after JMM supporters allegedly beat up students in several districts, including Hazaribagh, Giridih, and Ranchi.

Paswan is clear though that his JPSC-JSSC Reform Manch has only student members, unlike Mahto's JPSC-JSSC Abhyarthi Nyay Manch. "We do not want any political involvement, because the government should not say that we are in touch with any political party and make the issue political. I have no problem with Devendra Mah-toji; he is also raising the voice of the students."

Nearly 2,500 government employees, who had cleared the JSSC-CGL and other exams, were affected by the government's decision. On August 18, they staged a protest outside the Cabinet Secretariat for three days, demanding a roll back on the decision. The court put a stay on the government's order, and they returned to work on

BJP hails 1857 icon at Lodhi sabha event; SP questions 1 lakh jobs vow

Patriotism, bravery of freedom fighter Rani Avanti Bai Lodhi transcend social, gender barriers, says Rajnath; govt. to provide 50,000 scooters to women; Akhilesh says promise of jobs for youth made in run-up to U.P. poll; MCC to kick in from Jan. '27

Press Trust of India
LUCKNOW

Senior Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader and Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Sunday paid tribute to the 1857 freedom fighter Rani Avanti Bai Lodhi, saying her patriotism and bravery transcended all social and gender barriers.

"Beyond caste, gender" "Avanti Bai Lodhi taught that patriotism and bravery can't be confined to the boundaries of any caste, class or gender," said Mr. Singh at the event in Lucknow, organised by the Lodhi Kshatriya Rajput Sabha.

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, who was also present at the event, said no single individual, party or region can claim credit for India's freedom movement. He also hit out at Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav for not offering condolences on the death of former CM Kalyan Singh, a Lodhi leader.

Meanwhile, the SP chief took a swipe at Mr. Adityanath over his remark that his government will provide jobs to 1 lakh youth in



Defence Minister, senior BJP leader and party MP from Lucknow Rajnath Singh paying tribute to 1957 freedom fighter Avantibai Lodhi; SP chief Akhilesh Yadav addressing a press conference in Lucknow. PTI

the next six months.

"Now, with only a few days left, they are saying that 1 lakh jobs will be given. After January, the Model Code of Conduct will come into force," he said.

The Assembly election is due in early 2027.

Growing presence

The Defence Minister, who is an MP from Lucknow, and the CM hailed the role of women in different spheres, from bagging

sports medals to defending the country.

Avanti Bai not only challenged British rule but also confronted a system that underestimated women, Mr. Singh said, adding that her life is an example of women's empowerment.

"In the Army, sports ... India's women are demonstrating their capabilities. From the heights of Siachen to the depths of the seas, they are playing an important role in streng-

thening the country," said the Defence Minister.

Mr. Adityanath attacked the SP, alleging that its government had tried to close the Provincial Armed Constabulary (PAC).

Three all-woman PAC battalions have been formed, with one each stationed in Lucknow, Gorakhpur and Badaun. The battalion in Badaun is named after Avanti Bai Lodhi, he added.

The CM said his govern-

ment will provide scooters to 50,000 women as a tribute to Rani Lakshmi Bai.

"Govt. failed the poor" Addressing a media briefing at his party headquarters, the SP chief hit out at the BJP-led regime in U.P., accusing it of corruption and of "failing the poor".

The Kannauj MP also reiterated his promise of reopening 26,000 primary schools, which he said had been closed down during the Adityanath government, and again underlined his party's demand for a caste census and equitable rights for disadvantaged groups.

Last week, he had announced a 'Stree Samman Samridhhi Yojana' under which each woman would receive assistance of ₹40,000 every year. Mainpuri MP Dimple Yadav, who was also present at the announcement, had said, "Women's power will develop not merely by talking about it, but by giving true representation to women. Respect and prosperity of every woman included in the PDA as Aadhi Abadi (half the population, or women) is our resolve."



Divya Mittal announced her resignation on Sunday.

U.P. IAS officer resigns, terms her journey 'unforgettable'

Mavank Kumar
LUCKNOW

Uttar Pradesh-cadre IAS officer and former Deoria District Magistrate Divya Mittal announced her resignation on Sunday. She described her 13-year journey in the service as "unforgettable".

"After studying at IIT Delhi and IIM Bangalore, I worked day and night and landed a job in London. But even after having everything, something felt incomplete... So I returned and was fortunate to become an IAS officer," she wrote on X. Ms. Mittal added, "A single scene is etched in my heart: the elderly woman from the Lahuriya Dah Hills, who, seeing water in her village for the first time, said nothing but touched my head with trembling hands and blessed me."

No protests as 'anti-national' graffiti removed from Jadavpur University

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Grffiti at Kolkata's Jadavpur University (JU) was whitewashed following Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari's stern warning on August 28 to weed out "anti-national" elements from the campus. The university authorities said the drive was a part of the regular cleaning process and that the university did not want to be drawn into any controversy.

The process of putting white paint on the graffiti started on Saturday and continued till Sunday.

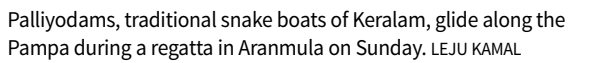
Some speak out

There have been no protests against the development, though some students, particularly those associated with Left students' unions, have spoken against the move.

Grffiti in support of Palestine and Maoist leader

Kishenji was whitewashed from the walls of the JU Arts hostel. A slogan on the open-air theatre that read, 'Fascists do not deserve democracy. They deserve a bullet in the head', was also covered with white paint. Also erased was a portrait of American civil rights activist Audre Lorde.

Grffiti and poster culture have been prevalent at the university for decades and are inseparable from the politics on campus.



The Hindu Bureau
KOLLAM

He praised the majestic, beautifully decorated *Palliyodams* powered by over a hundred oarsmen rowing in complete unison, serv-

Festivals, he observed, serve as a poignant reminder of the remarkable power of heritage to unite people and fortify social bonds. He pointed out that tradition and modernity are not conflicting forces, but rather pillars that can comfortably coexist. He added that while Kerala celebrates Onam, Odisha observes the Rath Yatra in Puri. He observed that a shared culture consistently binds the nation together. He also expressed his deep delight at having presided over the Rajya Sabha session during which the Bill to rename the State as “Keralam” was passed.

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The exposed rocky bed of the Cauvery at Hogenakkal in Tamil Nadu earlier this month. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A Bench is scheduled to

The amendment process has to be initiated by Parliament on a recommendation by the State executive and after ascertaining the views of the State judiciary,

The name changes introduced by the State government need not reflect on the name or character of the High Court. The judge also pointed out the instances of High Courts of Bombay, Calcutta, Madras and Orissa where the original names of the courts were retained despite the changes in the names of the respective States.

A special National Investigation Agency court in Bengaluru has sentenced a man over the 2020 Al-Hind ISIS terror conspiracy case to seven years of rigorous imprisonment. A fine of ₹48,000 has also been imposed on Syed Fasiur Rehman. Investigators said that the Al-Hind module planned targeted killings to trigger communal riots.

Race against time: An artisan from West Bengal paints eco-friendly idols made of clay brought from the Ganga, ahead of Ganesh Chaturthi, in the One Town area of Visakhapatnam on Sunday. The festival will be celebrated on September 14. K. R. DEEPAK

Both parties have their individual stances on whether or not to follow precedents in some cases, which are communicated to their cadre and followers, he said, and mocked the United Democratic Front (UDF) and the Indian



IUML national vice-president K.P.A. Majeed had on Saturday written an article in the party mouth-piece, *Chandrika*, eulogising the CPI and exhorting the CPI(M), which was widely seen as its invitation to the CPI to switch sides.

Instead of addressing that issue, if the CPI(M) tries to score a few points by reminding the CPI of its support for the Emergency, it will only serve to worsen the relationship between the two parties, he said.

Once fully operational, the project will provide drinking water for 23 lakh people and irrigation for 4.47 lakh acres. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

At a protest held to mark the 1,977th day of sit-in near the Gandhi statue at the Greater Visakhapatnam Municipal Corporation office, AITUC leaders sought a comprehensive revival package.

Yohaán Varghese
MUMBAI

Mr. Bagwe had raised concerns with the institute over an alleged incident of sexual harassment on campus via email, following

The Hindu Bureau
DINDIGUL

Police registered a case and nabbed the driver. Investigations suggested the driver Saravana Kumar was driving the vehicle in a rash and negligent manner.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

completed the e-KYC process.

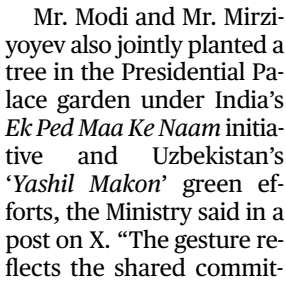
So far, e-KYC has been completed for 15.89 crore

Press Trust of India
LUDHIANA

The meeting on Sunday was attended by senior leaders of the employees' bodies, including Satish

Press Trust of India
TASHKENT

His “timeless call of ‘Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan’ continues to inspire generations,” the External Affairs Ministry said, adding that his life “embodied simplicity, courage and unwavering devotion to the nation.”



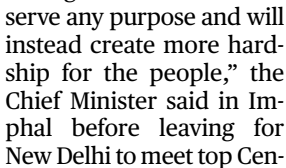
The tree-planting ceremony came after the Prime Minister held delegation-level talks with the Uzbek President at the Kuksaroy Presidential Palace as part

Later, Mr. Modi arrived in Kyrgyzstan, where he is to attend the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation summit.

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Diverging demands

The Meitei and Naga communities want the NRC to be updated before the Census is undertaken to weed



Home Minister Govindas Konthoujam said Manipur was prepared to conduct the NRC exercise within the constitutional and legal framework.

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

“The bodies of the four men were taken for post-mortem. Further investigation into the incident and the criminal cases linked to the group is under way,” a Meghalaya-based police official said.

BJP chief’s ideation session focuses on Gen-Z outreach

Some leaders suggest avoiding the term ‘Gen Z’ and instead using the broader term ‘youth’ or references to specific age groups; party decides to galvanise its existing voter base and cadres

Nistula Hebbar
NEW DELHI

BJP national president Nitin Nabin’s brainstorming session on Saturday on the party’s engagement with Gen Z included suggestions to abandon the term altogether and simply refer to the cohort as the “youth”, as well as initiating a simultaneous outreach to the party’s older voters.

The meeting in New Delhi, under a youth outreach initiative headed by Mr. Nabin, was attended by around 45 young leaders with party general secretary Smriti Irani and Chhattisgarh Minister O.P. Choudhary as committee members.

According to sources, participants were invited to share their views on how the party could improve dialogue and participation among young people.

Several attendees argued that it would be incorrect to treat all young people as a homogenous, single category, stressing that different groups of youth have distinct aspira-



The meeting under the youth outreach initiative was headed by BJP national president Nitin Nabin in New Delhi. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

tions and concerns.

Sources said some participants suggested avoiding the term “Gen Z” and instead using the broader term “youth” or references to specific age groups.

The “horizontal solidarity” among the age cohort witnessed during the recent Cockroach Janta Party (CJP)-led protests over the NEET exam paper ‘leak’ was one thing, said an attendee, but that did not mean that all young people shared the same life experiences or even aspirations. “Young people in Tier-two cities and villages will have different ideas about life, their opportuni-

ties and what they think on various issues,” they said, advocating for a graded engagement with different kinds of youngsters.

A number of participants underlined the need for differentiated engagement strategies and communication methods for various categories of young people.

One participant noted that while greater engagement with the youth is essential, the party must take care that older supporters and long-time party backers do not feel neglected or sidelined. Another suggested that energising the party’s veteran workers is just

as important as expanding outreach among youth, and that efforts should also be made to strengthen cadres’ confidence in the leadership.

The 45 participants in the meeting have reportedly been divided into five or six groups. Gujarat Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi and Chhattisgarh’s O.P. Choudhary are among those tasked with leading the groups. Participants have been asked to send their suggestions to their respective team leaders, who will compile them for further consideration.

All participants have been asked to submit their recommendations within the next seven or eight days.

According to sources, the recommendations gathered from these 45 leaders will be considered for implementation in future party programmes. Preparations are also under way for youth-focused activities during the coming “Seva Sankalp Mahotsav”, which will mark 25 years of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s public service journey.

Bihar Cong. leaders plan Delhi protest for removal of in-charge, State chief

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A group of Bihar Congress leaders has written to party president Mallikarjun Kharge, stating that they will stage a peaceful sit-in outside the party headquarters, Indira Bhavan, in New Delhi on September 8, unless the Bihar unit in-charge Krishna Allavaru and State president Rajesh Kumar are removed.

The proposed protest comes amid discontent within the Bihar Congress following its poor performance in the 2025 Assembly election, in which the party won six seats, down from 19 in 2020.

In a letter dated August 15, the workers alleged “disorder” in the Bihar Pradesh Congress Committee during the Assembly election and accused Mr. Allavaru of acting arbitrarily in the distribution of ticket.

Anand Madhab, former chairperson of the Congress Manifesto Committee for the 2020 Assembly election, said a delegation had met Mr. Kharge and other senior leaders on November 3, 2025, to raise concerns over the functioning of the State unit.



Bihar Congress national in-charge Krishna Allavaru and State president Rajesh Kumar. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

“We discussed how genuine workers were denied tickets and people from other parties got tickets. They promised to pay heed to us, but since then there has been no redress,” Mr. Madhab said.

The delegation submitted a representation to Mr. Kharge during the meeting and was assured that the complaints would be examined and action taken after the election, the letter said.

“More than 10 months have passed, and the Bihar Congress is going from bad to worse. Therefore, we are left with no other option than to protest before the headquarters,” Mr. Madhab said.

Senior Congress leader from Bihar, Kishore Kumar

Jha, supported the concerns raised by the workers, but said their grievances could be addressed through discussions. “They are dedicated Congress workers, and the party high command should listen to their grievances,” Mr. Jha said.

The protesters include former Bihar Congress vice-presidents Jamal Ahmed and Rajkumar Rajan, AICC member Nagendra Paswan, former MLA Chhatrapati Yadav, former BPCC secretary B. Akhtar, and former MLA Anil Kumar Singh.

The signatories said their campaign was aimed at saving the party organisation in Bihar and urged the leadership to meet them before September 8.

OBC groups seek unique code for castes in Census

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A national OBC conference on Sunday demanded that the Union government make caste enumeration mandatory in the nationwide Census and assign a separate “unique code” to every caste. Conducting a Census without these measures would be a waste of public money, and the exercise should be halted until a nationwide consensus is reached on the issue, OBC leaders said.

The conference was chaired by former IAS officer and chairman of the Backward Classes Intellectual Forum T. Chiranjeevulu, and All India OBC Students Association president G. Kiran Kumar.

Without assigning a unique code to every caste, the speakers said, the Census could not be scientifically sound. “Just as separate columns are provided for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, separate columns should also be created for OBCs and the General Category,” several speakers said.

The speakers also cautioned the government that a nationwide movement could follow if their demand was ignored.

National law varsity yet to take shape in Uttarakhand

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The recent student protests at some National Law Universities (NLUs) over institutional accountability have put the spotlight on Uttarakhand, where 15 years after its Assembly approved a law to establish an NLU, the State does not have a single functional law university.

The delay stands out when compared with the two other States created in November 2000 – Chhattisgarh and Jharkhand. While Chhattisgarh established the Hidayatullah National Law University in Raipur in 2003, Jharkhand set up the National University of Study and Research in Law in Ranchi in 2010.

Former Uttarakhand Chief Minister Harish Rawat said students of the State were suffering because of the delay in setting up an NLU campus. “This issue has been caught in the BJP’s petty internal politics but students are paying a price.”

The Uttarakhand legislature passed the National Law University Act in 2011. Fifteen years later, the proposed institution has neither a permanent campus nor students. Its location has shifted repeatedly: from Bhowali in Nainital district to Pantnagar in Udham Singh Nagar and Ranipokhari near Dehradun and now Haldwani is under consideration.

The uncertainty over Uttarakhand’s NLU site reached the High Court, which in 2018 directed the State government to establish the university. The court also said that academic sessions need not wait for a permanent campus and could begin from a government building or rented premises. In 2019, then Chief Minister Trivendra Singh Rawat laid the foundation stone at Ranipokhari for what was projected as the country’s 23rd NLU. Seven years later, the university remains non-functional.

Justice Bhuyan calls for appointing ‘brilliant minds’ from legal academia as judges in SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

As student bodies across premier national universities object to Chief Justice of India Surya Kant’s remarks and refuse to have him over for their convocations, Supreme Court judge Justice Ujjal Bhuyan on Sunday pushed for the activation of presidential power to directly appoint “distinguished jurists”, including legal academicians, as judges in the top court of the country.

“While our Constitution has a provision for appointment of a jurist as a judge of the Supreme Court, no jurist has been appointed so far to the Supreme Court though the Constitution has completed more than 76 years,” Justice Bhuyan pointed out at the 13th convocation of the National Law University, Delhi.

Justice Bhuyan said that as important as the right to question was the tolerance to disagreement. “A democratic society cannot be built on the edifice that



Supreme Court judge Justice Ujjal Bhuyan says a ‘distinguished jurist’ could be a great value addition to the Bench. PTI

everyone will think alike,” he said.

Bar Council row

The comments from the Supreme Court judge follow a recent debacle by the Bar Council of India, which ordered State Bar Councils to bar the professional enrolment of the 2026 batch of NALSAR students for objecting to have CJI Kant over as the chief guest for their convocation over his oral comments in court using terms such as “cockroach” and “parasites”.

The BCI had to retract the order after public pressure.

“Tolerance is not merely a matter of personal courtesy. It is a constitutional value. A democracy becomes meaningful not when everyone speaks the same language of thought, but when different voices can co-exist, be heard and be treated with dignity,” Justice Bhuyan said.

The judge said the maturity of a democracy was reflected not merely in how it responded to opinions that were difficult, unpopular or inconvenient. The courage to voice unpopular opinions began

at universities, the Supreme Court judge said. He said the 76-year reluctance to activate Article 124(3) for appointment of legal academics as Supreme Court judges in the category of “distinguished jurists” may have been either due to the feeling that there was not enough “depth in the Indian academia” or because the provision was simply not seriously taken. As a result, brilliant minds, men and women with legal scholarship, who could have significantly contributed on the Bench missed the opportunity to serve as judges of the Supreme Court.

Justice Bhuyan dismissed the oft-repeated argument that legal academics and scholars lack the practical experience that serve judges. “But this is a very shallow objection. Supreme Court is not only the highest adjudicatory body but it is the moral, legal and constitutional conscience keeper of the nation. It is above technicalities. The reason for having this provision of

distinguished jurist in Article 124(3) is to diversify the Bench with talented judges,” he said.

Who is a jurist?

In India, the judge said, the term “jurist” was being applied very loosely.

“A lawyer or a judge of repute is often described as a jurist. Certainly, a lawyer and a judge can be a jurist, and there are many such instances, but in the context of Article 124(3), it extends beyond the above two categories. A person who is skilled in law or knowledgeable in the field of law would be qualified to be termed as a ‘jurist,’” Justice Bhuyan said.

A ‘distinguished jurist’ could be a great value addition to the Bench. By his or her scholarship, he or she can make a visible contribution to the decision-making process at the top level. Participation of renowned legal academia and scholars would have a defining impact on the judicial functioning of the Supreme Court, Justice Bhuyan said.

Delay in prorogation of Parliament leading to suspicion: Ramesh

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Speculation abounds about a possible Special Session of Parliament to revive the Delimitation Bill, with the Monsoon Session yet to be prorogued, or formally ended, 17 days after the last meeting of the House.

On August 13, both the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha were adjourned *sine die*, bringing Parliament’s Monsoon Session to a close.

However, the session is yet to end formally. It remains technically alive, allowing the government to reconvene Parliament without issuing a fresh presidential summons.

The Congress has continued to press for clarity, questioning the unusual delay. “The continued delay in prorogation is mystifying and certainly leads to suspicions that some mischief is afoot. The Home Minister does not have a super-tainted two-thirds majority and is probably



Jairam Ramesh

engaging in mind games of bluff and bluster,” Congress communications chief Jairam Ramesh told *The Hindu*.

Party president Mallikarjun Kharge, in a letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday, reiterated the party’s position on delimitation and the expansion of the Lok Sabha, insisting that the existing strength of the Lower House be frozen at 543 seats for next 15 years.

The Congress chief also sought the implementation of the legislation to reserve a third of the seats for women MPs in the 2029 Lok Sabha election.

Tejashwi asks Chirag, Manjhi to fight from unreserved seats

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Amid the verbal clash between Bihar’s two Union Ministers, Chirag Paswan and Jitan Ram Manjhi, over reservation and demands for each other’s resignation, Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) leader Tejashwi Yadav on Sunday dared both of them to contest elections from unreserved seats. Earlier, Mr. Manjhi and his son Santosh Kumar Suman had sought a review of the reservation policy and sub-categorisation of Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes.

Reacting to their state-

ment, Mr. Paswan said that if they talked about the creamy layer, then both father and son should resign as they too fall under the creamy layer. Mr. Yadav alleged that both Union Ministers were acting on Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh’s (RSS) instructions. He said both were speaking in contradictory terms to divert attention from the BJP-RSS’s agenda of abolishing reservation.

“If they hold such intense hatred for reservation, they should start contesting elections from unreserved seats; that would open their eyes,” Mr. Yadav said.

T.N. firms ditch conservative image for IPO push

Sangeetha Kandavel
CHENNAI

Several relatively newer Tamil Nadu-based business houses are shedding their conservative tag and knocking on the doors of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) to tap into the initial public offering (IPO) market. Milky Mist, headquartered in Erode, and Chennai-based Lalithaa Jewellery have already gone public this year and witnessed strong subscription.

A few more are expected to join the queue in the coming months.

Chennai-headquartered drone technology company Garuda Aerospace and a consumer durables company Sathya Agencies are also expected to join the



From left, Ashish Chauhan, CEO, National Stock Exchange, with T. Satish Kumar, CMD, Milky Mist, and K. Rathnam, CEO, Milky Mist. FILE

IPO queue.

“Each year, around three to four companies from Tamil Nadu are getting listed,” said an analyst tracking the markets. Over the last three years, several Tamil Nadu-based companies including Avalon Technologies Ltd., R.K. Swamy Ltd., Northern Arc

Capital Ltd., Dr. Agarwal’s Healthcare Ltd., and Glottis Ltd., have tapped into the IPO market.

“The promoter-driven mindset is slowly changing. People have started realising that if I own 100% of the company, its value may be ₹100, but if I share at least 25% with the pu-

blic, the company’s value could rise to ₹500. “That kind of value creation was not known earlier,” said Nagappan Valliappan, a capital market professional, who was the former chairman of the Federation of Indian Stock Exchanges.

“If you look at family businesses in Tamil Nadu, many of them are now in their third or fourth generation. There are family disputes and divisions taking place. As a result, some businesses feel it is better to go public, and after a point, sell the company rather than deal with family tussles,” said a source who has been dealing with family businesses in Tamil Nadu.

Pranav Haldea, MD of Prime Database Group,

said: “What you are seeing in Tamil Nadu is what I like to call the ‘net worth creation effect’. This has happened across India over the last five-six years. Class B/C towns and cities in India have been largely dominated by family-controlled and closely held businesses that were never too keen on getting outside investors. What happened was a few IPOs of such type of companies started happening and others saw the kind of valuation and net worth creation that can happen when value is unlocked through an IPO, with several of these promoters becoming millionaires or even billionaires. This triggered a sense of FOMO (fear of missing out) among other family-owned businesses.”

INBRIEF



FPIs turn buyers for second month, invest ₹30,919 crore

Foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) infused ₹30,919 crore in Indian equities in August, extending their buying streak to a second straight month, amid improving corporate earnings, resilient economic activity, stable rupee and easing geopolitical concerns. The inflow follows ₹20,200 crore invested in July, marking a sharp turnaround after four consecutive months of heavy selling. FPIs had withdrawn ₹49,340 crore in June, ₹32,963 crore in May, ₹60,847 crore in April, and a massive ₹1.17 lakh crore in March. Prior to the selling streak, they had invested ₹22,615 crore in February, according to Central Depository Services (India) Ltd. (CDSL) data. PTI

Four die after consuming spurious liquor in Patna

At least four people died allegedly after consuming spurious liquor in dry Bihar's Patna district on Sunday, a police officer said. The incident took place in Bedhna village under the jurisdiction of the Barh police station. According to the families of the deceased, the four men consumed liquor in a room, and they fell ill soon after. They were taken to the nearest government hospital, where they died during treatment. Barh Sub-Divisional Police Officer (SDPO) Ayush Srivastava said the bodies of the victims had been sent for post-mortem examination to ascertain the exact cause of death. The Bihar government imposed a total ban on the sale and consumption of alcohol in the State on April 5, 2016. PTI

Modi stresses need to keep India's youth free from drugs

Students, theatre groups must raise awareness against drug menace, says PM in his *Mann ki Baat* address; 35 lakh women across the country have benefited from PM SVANidhi Yojana, he adds

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has flagged the dangers of drug addiction, highlighted the economic avenues opening up for women and girls in India, including in the space industry, and lauded the cleanliness initiatives being undertaken by citizens. “Drug addiction does not just engulf a single individual. The entire family and society have to bear the consequences,” Mr. Modi said in his 137th *Mann ki Baat* episode on Sunday. “I would like to commend those who raise awareness against drugs and step forward to help individuals struggling with addiction.” Mr. Modi urged young musicians to produce songs that convey the message of a drug-free life, students and theatre groups to write short plays that highlight the dangers of drugs while also showing the path to recovery, and content creators to spread the message on social media in various languages. “Let us all play our part in this noble mission to



keep India's youth away from drugs and free from addiction,” Mr. Modi said. **Women empowerment** “From morning till evening, lakhs of women across the streets of our cities and towns are engaged in their work,” the Prime Minister noted. “Some sell vegetables or fruits, others run tea stalls, while some sell flowers, earthen lamps, and worship materials.” He added that, often, a lack of capital prevents such businesses from growing further. “But now, lakhs of such mothers and sisters are gaining new strength through the PM SVANidhi Yojana,” Mr. Modi said. “This aspect of wo-

men empowerment is not discussed as much as it should be. Women account for approximately 46% of the beneficiaries of the PM SVANidhi Yojana.” This, he explained, meant that around 35 lakh women across the country are expanding their businesses by connecting with this scheme. PM SVANidhi Yojana is a Central government scheme aimed at providing affordable and easy working capital loans without any guarantee to street vendors and hawkers in urban areas. “Today the flight of our daughters' dreams is soaring from the earth to outer space,” Mr. Modi told listeners of his radio programme. “And

you will be proud to know that India is bringing together thousands of daughters who are nurturing such dreams, from across the globe. This initiative is named Mission ShaktiSAT.” Through this initiative, 12,000 girl students from 108 countries are getting the opportunity to learn satellite technology and to advance in the field of innovation, he said. On August 23, celebrated as National Space Day, the second phase of Mission ShaktiSAT was launched at Gautam Buddha University in Greater Noida where around 100 female students from across the country, including remote regions, and various other countries came together. “The goal of this entire initiative is truly special: preparations are under way to send a satellite – developed entirely through the participation of female students – into lunar orbit,” Mr. Modi said. “I am confident that many of these students will carve out a distinct identity for themselves in the fields of science, technology, and innovation in the future.”

Power failure hits two NEET-PG exam centres in Jaipur

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI



A total of 2,65,980 candidates appeared for the examination conducted on Sunday. ANI

The National Board of Examinations in Medical Sciences (NBEMS) on Sunday constituted a three-member committee to investigate the internal power supply failure that disrupted the NEET-PG 2026 examination at two iON Digital Zone iDZ Sitapura centres in Jaipur, Rajasthan, sources in the NBEMS said. The NBEMS conducted the NEET-PG examination on Sunday. The examination was scheduled for 2,73,096 candidates at 1,111 examination centres across 339 cities, covering all 36 States and Union Territories. A total of 2,65,980 candidates appeared for the examination and 2,527 faculty members were appointed as Independent Appraisers to oversee the conduct of the examination. In addition, more than 700 senior faculty members, including Deans, Directors, Medical Superintendents and senior professors, were deployed in flying squads. “However, a technical disruption occurred at iON Digital Zone iDZ Sitapura Centres, Jaipur, Rajasthan (TC Nos. 41682 and 41683),

where the examination could not be completed for 2,445 candidates due to internal power supply issues at the test centres, attributable to TCS Ltd., the examination conducting agency,” the Union Health Ministry said. The re-examination for the affected candidates will be conducted at 3 p.m. on September 5 in Jaipur. The committee has been constituted to examine the circumstances leading to the power supply failure and ascertain the reasons for the disruption. It includes a senior official from the Government of Rajasthan, a Joint Secretary-level officer from the Ministry, and a senior engineering official from the Central Electricity Authority.

Govt. notifies IST as common time reference across India; gives 180 days for compliance

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI



The Centre is building facilities to disseminate accurate IST. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

The Union government has notified the Legal Metrology (Indian Standard Time) Rules, 2026, mandating Indian Standard Time (IST) as the single reference for legal, administrative, commercial and other official purposes across the country. The nodal Consumer Affairs Ministry notified the rules on August 27. Still, they will come into force 180 days after their publication in the Official Gazette, giving government departments, businesses, and institutions time to align their systems. The move comes amid growing reliance on digital and technology-based systems—from banking and payments to telecommuni-

port accurate time-stamping of banking and digital payment transactions, coordination among railways, airports and other transport systems, reliable functioning of telecommunication and internet networks, precise time-keeping in power systems, upkeep of government and legal records, and coordination of emergency and other time-critical services, the Ministry said in a statement. A key feature of the rules is the emphasis on reducing dependence on foreign satellite-based time sources, which several critical systems currently rely on. The government is building infrastructure to disseminate accurate IST through Indian institutions and legal metrology laboratories. The common time reference is expected to sup-

port accurate time-stamping of banking and digital payment transactions, coordination among railways, airports and other transport systems, reliable functioning of telecommunication and internet networks, precise time-keeping in power systems, upkeep of government and legal records, and coordination of emergency and other time-critical services, the Ministry said in a statement. A key feature of the rules is the emphasis on reducing dependence on foreign satellite-based time sources, which several critical systems currently rely on. The government is building infrastructure to disseminate accurate IST through Indian institutions and legal metrology laboratories. The common time reference is expected to sup-

Study sheds light on early warning signs before eruption of solar flares

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU



Scientists found numerous small, short-lived brightening 'transient events', occurring before the onset of major flares. GETTY IMAGES

In a new study, scientists have found small, short-lived brightening in the sun's atmosphere that appear hours before a major solar flare erupts, clustering around the spot where the flare later occurs. The study was carried out by researchers from the Manipal Centre for Natural Sciences and Manipal Academy of Higher Education, along with scientists from the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), Department of Space, and other academicians. It used simultaneous ultraviolet (UV) and X-ray observations from three payloads onboard the Aditya-L1 mission. The Solar Ultraviolet Imaging Telescope (SUIT) payload observed the sun in 11 near-ultraviolet (NUV)

filters, revealing different layers from the upper photosphere to chromosphere, according to the ISRO. “NUV wavelengths are largely inaccessible from the ground because Earth's atmosphere absorbs most ultraviolet radiation. Complementing SUIT are two X-ray instruments, the Solar Low Energy X-ray Spectrometer (SoLEXS) and the High Energy L1 Orbiting X-ray Spectrometer (HELIOS), which measure

the X-ray emission produced by energetic processes in the solar corona. Combining these data, scientists study how activity in the lower solar atmosphere is linked to energy release in the corona during the build-up to a flare,” the ISRO stated. Analysing solar flare events, the team found numerous small, short-lived brightening ‘transient events’, occurring in active regions before the onset of

major flares. “Some of these also showed corresponding X-ray signatures, indicating that they involve the release of magnetic energy... These pre-flare transient events clustered around the location where the major flare later occurred. The results suggest that repeated small-scale energy release may progressively destabilise the magnetic field in an active region, eventually leading to a large solar flare,” the ISRO said. The findings provide valuable insights into the physical processes that trigger solar flares and move scientists a step closer towards reliable flare forecasting, which will ultimately contribute to better space weather prediction; help protect satellites, astronauts, and communication systems; and other critical technologies.

Black flags waved at Maharashtra Deputy CM

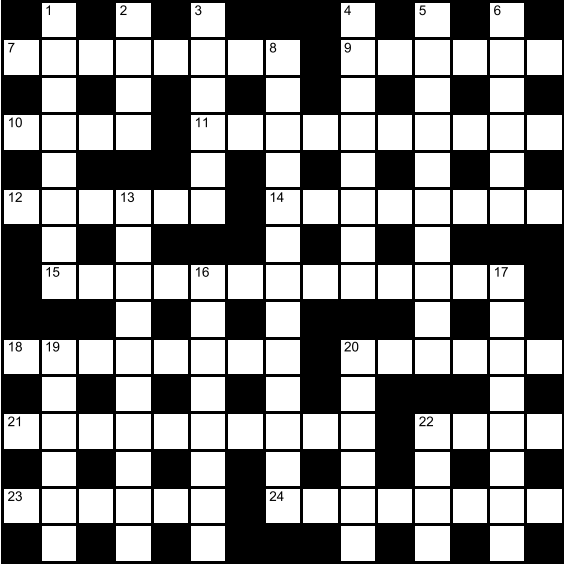
The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Maratha protesters waved black flags at Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde during the Shiv Sena's farmer-youth interaction programme in Parbhani on Sunday. The protest comes amid the ongoing indefinite hunger strike by Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange Patil, who is demanding Kunbi caste certificates for the Maratha community. Parbhani is part of the Marathwada division and is located 155 km from Antarwadi Sarati in Jalna district, the site of the protest. During the event, Mr. Shinde said, “We [Mahayuti government] formed the Shinde committee to give reservation, we also gave 10% reservation to the Maratha community.”

**THE HINDU****CROSSWORD****+****14886**
(set by Hypatia)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

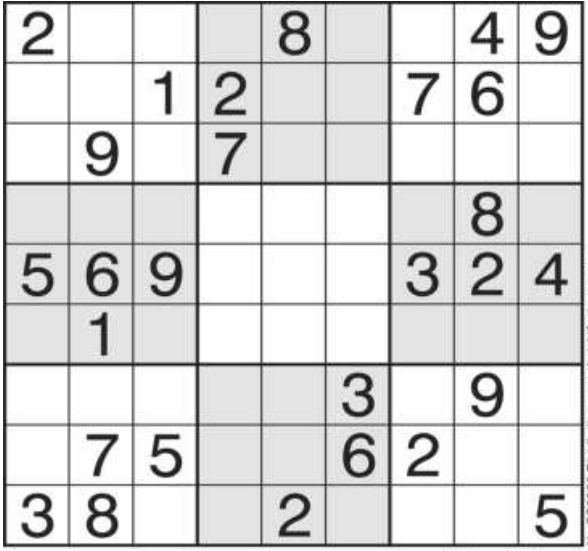
SCAN TO PLAY



Across
7 Legal nationalist forces fighting to secure independence (8)
9 Model saving time for second sibling (6)
10 Defeat armoured vehicle (4)
11 Communicate with men hiring registered vendor (10)

12 Doctor separating wounded and serious (6)
14 Protect Sinner — He's lost (8)
15 A scene from Tom & Jerry, possibly in a temporary rally? (4,3,6)
18 Shot group of journalists per Spooner (8)
20 Local icon's clothing fabric (6)
21 Setter in main marketplace (4,6)
22 Field manager regularly clearing sink (4)
23 Keep checking elephants on vacation in jungle (6)
24 Win back in random plan (8)
Down
1 Decline screening said overs set up in camera (8)
2 Eat bananas closer to thick tree (4)
3 Tipsy chemist bottling spirit (6)
4 European crowd introduced to very strong coffee (8)
5 Rich saloon exercises happening at identical intervals (10)
6 Pity engineer spoiling Onam (6)
8 Vanity firm is sentenced wrongly (13)
13 Initially bride needs husband: revolting to go becomes a disgrace to family (5,5)
16 Virtue of unwinding by a trip to spa which is taken frequently (8)
17 Trade banter (8)
19 Yes, this author made say, movies (6)
20 Provides automobiles without deflated tyre (6)
22 Originally France exported tuna and cheese (4)

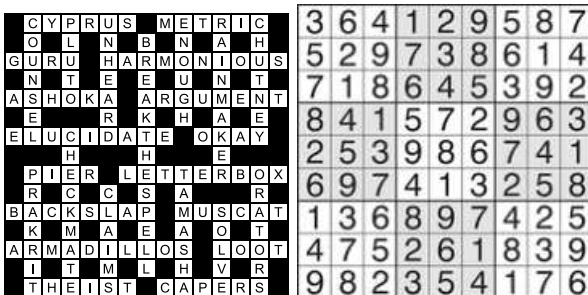
SUDOKU



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku



FAITH

Hari hurries to devotees

Whenever a devotee is in distress, Perumal rushes to his aid as soon as the distress call is made. No matter the magnitude of the problem, if one chants Hari nama, Perumal will appear at one's side. Perumal's abundant love is not restricted to great devotees alone, but also to past sinners who have corrected their ways and surrendered to Him. He grants them moksha, said Tirukkudanthai Dr. Venkatesh.

In Krita yuga, three asuras - Thanjakan, Dandakan and Gajamukhan - had undertaken severe penance, praying to Siva, seeking the boon of everlasting life. When Siva said all humans have to perish in their physical form, they prayed and were granted their wish that death should never come to them in the hands of Siva. The three became egoistic and troubled the entire universe. They interrupted the severe penance being undertaken by sage Parasara, father of Vyasa. Rather than curse them, Parasara cried, 'Hari' three times. Hearing His devotee's cry, Perumal first dispatched Garuda, asking him to vanquish the three, following close behind. The flap of Garuda's wings sent up such fear among the army of the asuras that they all scattered. Perumal arrived like a dark cloud (*Neelamegam*) and aiming at Thanjakan, released the Chakra. The minute the sacred discus touched him, the asura, realising his mistakes and aware that death was upon him, surrendered to Perumal with folded hands. Perumal granted him mukti. Thanjakan sought a boon from Perumal, asking for the town to be named after him. Thanjakan further prayed that He remain in the site, enabling devotees to surrender to Him, Neelamega Perumal, and attain mukti.

How a star with an extreme magnetic field could prove space is not empty

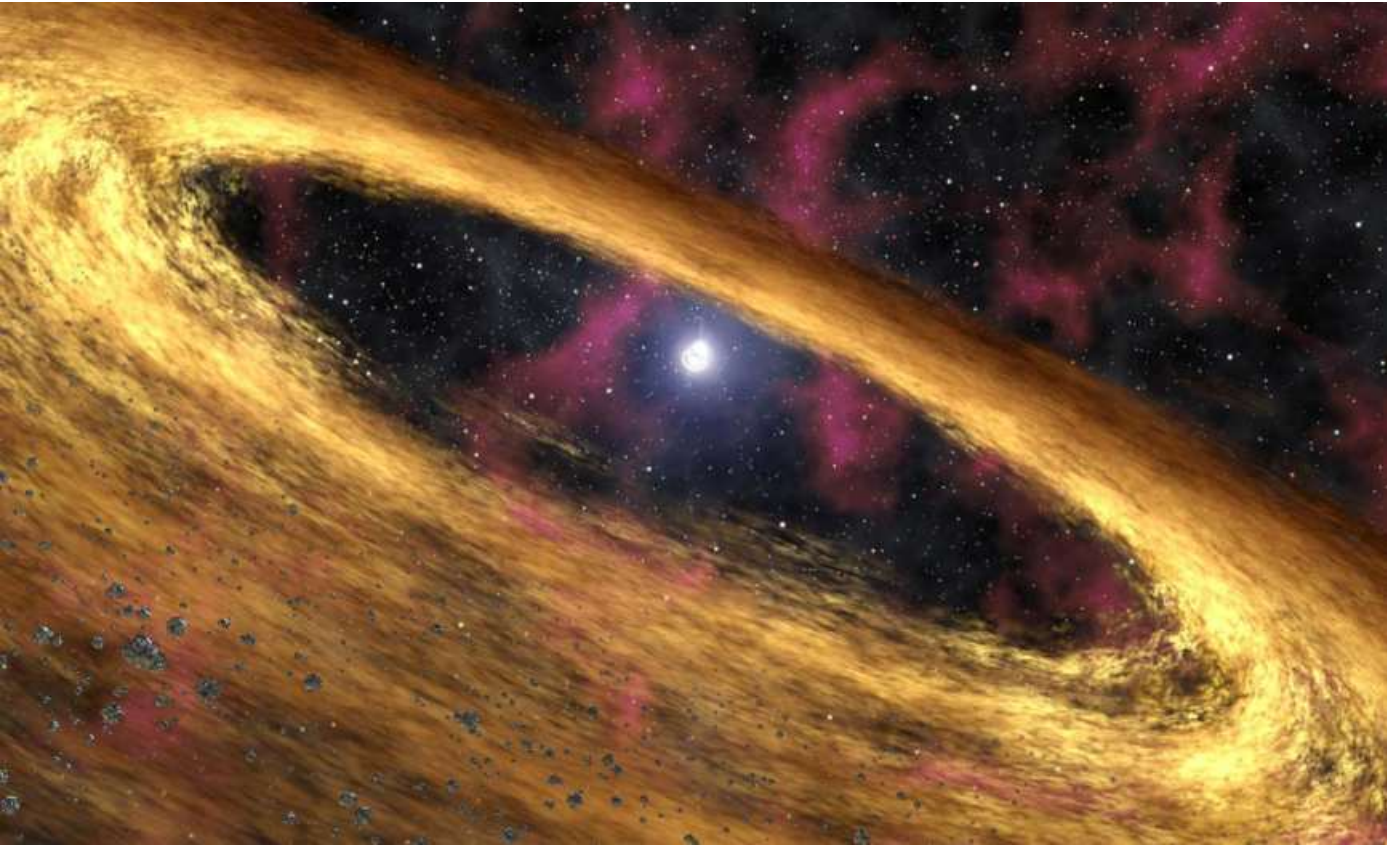
The work could pave the way to show that the ‘nothingness’ of space is actually a complex and active medium, and help scientists refine their maps of the universe

Vasudevan Mukunth

Quantum physics has made numerous strange predictions, and scientists have checked and confirmed many of them. But one of the strangest ones persists unresolved. In the 1930s, the German physicists Werner Heisenberg and Hans Heinrich Euler proposed that empty space is not really empty. Instead, they predicted that in the presence of a magnetic field, the vacuum of space would behave like a crystal, changing the properties of light passing through it. The trouble with testing this prediction – called vacuum birefringence – is that the magnetic field has to be extraordinarily strong. In a study published in *Nature* on August 5, astronomers from Australia, Canada, Japan, South Africa, Taiwan, and the U.S. reported it had observed such birefringence using two satellites and a telescope in Australia, almost confirming the prediction at long last. The work could prove ‘nothingness’ is actually a complex and active medium and also potentially help scientists refine their maps of the universe.

Staggering numbers

In classical physics, a vacuum is absolute nothingness. But in quantum electrodynamics (QED) – which is a theory in quantum physics – a vacuum is a soup of virtual particles: pairs of electrons and anti-electrons that constantly pop in and out of existence, and so quickly that they cannot be observed. Normally, these virtual particles have a negligible effect on light. But when a magnetic field nearby becomes strong enough, it changes how the short-lived charged particles can move, so they respond differently to light depending on the direction in which its electric field is vibrating. This part of space will then behave like a calcite crystal when light passes through it, splitting it into different paths depending on its electric field. (As an electromagnetic wave, light consists of electric and magnetic fields travelling through space.) For vacuum birefringence to become noticeable, the magnetic field has to be around 88 trillion times stronger than the earth’s magnetic field, and more than 500 million times as strong as the ultra-powerful magnets in the world’s largest science experiment, the CERN supercollider. These are staggering numbers far beyond the abilities of current technologies, so physicists have been looking for proof of vacuum birefringence in outer space, where objects called magnetars generate the



An artist's impression of the magnetar 4U 0142+61. In May 2022, the IXPE satellite had hinted at vacuum birefringence around this dead star. NASA

universe’s most extreme magnetic fields. Sometimes the core of a dead star can collapse to form a neutron star. Neutron stars with powerful magnetic fields are called magnetars. **Railroading polarisation** The international team focused its attention on one magnetar named 1E 1547.0-5408, located 14,700 lightyears away. As independent experts Ekaterina Sokolova-Lapa and Joern Wilms wrote in a commentary accompanying the team’s paper, “1E 1547.0-5408 belongs to a rare subclass of magnetars that also emit pulses at radio wavelengths”. By combining X-ray and radio frequency measurements, then, the team could piece together the geometry of the magnetar’s magnetic field. If the vacuum of space were truly empty – as in classical physics – the X-rays from the magnetar would reach the earth with a low degree of polarisation. But the team found the opposite: the NASA Imaging X-ray Polarimetry Explorer (IXPE) satellite in particular detected very high levels of polarisation, up to 80% in some instances, which is the smoking gun of vacuum birefringence. As X-rays leave the magnetar and move through the surrounding space, QED predicts that their electric field will have to lock itself into one of two directions – a condition that unmagnetised space does not impose – thus polarising the light.

Since these directions are defined by the direction of the magnetic field, the X-rays’ polarisation is effectively railroaded along the magnetic field lines. And as the X-rays travel away from the magnetar, their polarisation will stay fixed even as the magnetic field becomes less and less able to ‘hold on’. According to the team, the amount of polarisation dropped as the energy of the X-rays increased, which QED predicts as well. The team was also able to elucidate that the magnetar rotated along an axis that aligned almost perfectly with its magnetic poles, like a top spinning upright – a detail that informed the team’s models of how the X-rays from the magnetar would look with and without vacuum birefringence. The models that did not account for the phenomenon fit substantially worse with the telescope data than those that included it. **Direct observation** Other than IXPE, the team had also used the Neutron Star Interior Composition Explorer instrument onboard the International Space Station and the Murriyang radio telescope in Australia. The finding takes a big step towards bolstering space’s character as a complex medium that both gravity and magnetism can manipulate. On a final note, the team wrote in its paper that its next goal is “to more

directly probe the nature of the ... polarisation”. And this, the commentary noted, requires “coordinated astronomical campaigns that observe multiple magnetars and cover a wider part of the electromagnetic spectrum”. The current finding is indirect because the astronomers recorded polarised light and inferred from that that it had passed through extremely magnetised space. **Not yet proven** As Sokolova-Lapa and Wilms put it, the high polarisation reported in the study only proves vacuum birefringence if the team’s model of the magnetar’s geometry is correct. If, instead, its axis of rotation and magnetic poles are further apart, the X-rays could have been polarised by plasma on the magnetar’s surface. A paper published in *The Astrophysical Journal* by researchers from Italy, Spain, and the U.K. has already raised doubts about the alignment. Physicists are also interested in the vacuum resonance: a distinctive dip in the polarisation – from one of the two allowed directions to the other – at a specific energy level. The international team itself reported a dip but said it was too noisy to be dispositive. But one way or another, the dark voids between the stars we see when we look up are far from dead, buzzing with activity. (mukunth.v@thehindu.co.in)

THE GIST

In the presence of strong magnetic fields, a phenomenon called vacuum birefringence can make the vacuum of space behave like a crystal and polarise light passing through it. Using NASA’s IXPE satellite, NICER instrument, and Australia’s Murriyang radio telescope, researchers observed highly polarised X-rays from magnetar 1E 1547.0-5408, matching predictions made by quantum electrodynamics (QED). The evidence depends on models of the magnetar’s geometry, and some scientists suggest the observed polarisation could instead be caused by plasma near the star; further observations of more magnetars are needed for a direct confirmation.

BIG SHOT



A worker at a robusta coffee bean plantation in Sao Gabriel da Palha, Brazil. A new study has challenged the widely held belief that robusta coffee is more resilient to climate change than other varieties, with its lead author in an interview calling it an ‘Internet myth’ based on flawed research that overlooked the crop’s drought intolerance and other vulnerabilities. REUTERS

WHAT IS IT?

Nancy Grace Roman Telescope



A computer generated model of the Nancy Grace Roman Telescope. NASA

Reuters

NASA is preparing to launch its next flagship space observatory — one scientists plan to use to investigate some of the universe’s biggest mysteries, including dark energy and dark matter, while also testing gravity at vast scales and hunting for planets beyond our solar system. The Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope is a roughly \$4-billion project. At the time of writing, it was planned for a Sunday launch from the NASA Kennedy Space Center in Florida. The observatory will be lofted into orbit aboard a SpaceX Falcon Heavy rocket. The telescope is named after the late Nancy Grace Roman, NASA’s first chief astronomer. It is a follow-on to the Hubble Space Telescope, launched in 1990, and the James Webb Space Telescope, launched in 2021, and has capabilities that can expand on the knowledge gained by those pioneering observatories, both of which also still operate. The telescope’s

main survey will take more than a year, per Roman’s senior project scientist Julie McEnery. “The survey will contain over two billion galaxies and enable us to study how the structures in our universe — the stars, the galaxies, the clusters of galaxies — grew and evolved. We’ll also measure how our universe has expanded over time,” she said. After launch and separation from the rocket, the telescope will travel towards a location called Lagrange point 2, about 1.6 million km from the earth. Webb also resides at this location. U.S. President Donald Trump tried during both his first and second terms to reduce or eliminate funding for Roman but the Congress preserved it.



For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’



State of exception

India must not normalise a culture of discrimination

In its first review by the U.N. Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination (CERD) since 2007, India has elicited an expression of “grave concern” about reports of the law enforcement apparatus resorting to violence – physical and otherwise – against minority ethnic and ethno-religious groups, Dalits, and non-citizens over the years. The Committee also noted that India, which ratified the International Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Racial Discrimination in 1968, has not provided detailed and updated information about the state’s inquiries and sanctions arising from allegations of such violence. While the government has told CERD that caste bias falls outside Article 1 of the convention because caste is not synonymous with race, CERD has allowed all forms of discrimination based on inherited status. The Committee’s concerns also span the practice of manual cleaning of sewers despite a law banning it; hate speech against, poor living conditions of, and the mass refolement of Rohingya Muslims; the mass deprivation of citizenship via the National Register of Citizens; large-scale deletions from the Special Intensive Revisions of electoral rolls; the government’s use of the FCRA, UAPA, AFSPA, and PMLA instruments to hamper the work of civil society organisations; the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita not expressly criminalising racist hate speech; and the Forest (Conservation) Amendment Act exempting “national security” projects from consultative decision-making.

Given these issues and the fragmented recourse available, the lack of suitably disaggregated data on disenfranchised communities, including due to a much-delayed Census and the slow release of NCRB data, has transcended the bounds of administrative lethargy to actively impeding independent checks of India’s claims about fighting caste- and faith-based discrimination. In fact, India has been implementing “special measures” based on 2011 Census data, which could mask a regression in the socioeconomic status of Scheduled Tribes and Adivasis. Together with the Global Alliance of National Human Rights Institutions recommending the downgrade of the NHRC last year, following the government appointing police officers to investigative roles and a lack of pluralism, CERD is effectively stepping into a vacuum. The road ahead remains clear, from restoring the NHRC’s independence and criminalising hate speech to supportive affirmative action, collecting and publishing disaggregated data, and improving the transparency of the electoral roll revisions, and strengthening enforcement overall. But if the government’s attempted use of a technicality to keep the issues of 200 million Dalits a “domestic matter” and avoid international accountability – and its dismissal of CERD’s concerns as politically motivated – is any guide, the task continues to fall to civil society to exert influence in multilateral fora and sustain political, legal, and administrative resistance to government choices that normalise India’s sadly widespread culture of discrimination of all sorts.

Drawn to defeat

India is now in a must-win situation in the Test Championship cycle

This was a triumph that ironically suffered the after-effects of a loss. India’s 1-0 series victory in the two-Test outing recently in Sri Lanka, in normal circumstances, would have been seen as a positive. However, in the race for key points in the ICC World Test Championship (WTC) cycle, the ideal India-centric result would have been a clean sweep at 2-0. But with Dhananjaya de Silva’s men thwarting India’s bid for a win in the second Test at Colombo’s Sinhalese Sports Club Ground, and forcing a draw, the visitors continue to occupy the fifth slot in the WTC rankings. It is a position one below Bangladesh after the eastern neighbour secured a 1-1 draw against Australia in the series Down Under. If a WTC final berth has to be secured then India has to do extremely well away against New Zealand and at home against Australia, and then hope that the various permutations cropping up will be favourable. Shubman Gill’s men find themselves in this piquant situation due to their vulnerability at home, having lost a Test series to South Africa last year. The transition angst within the Indian unit is yet to abate following the exit of R. Ashwin, Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma. Slowly, new heroes are emerging and the results could improve.

Stepping into the Emerald Isle and hamstrung by the injured Jasprit Bumrah’s absence, India did its homework. A warm-up fixture was won, while some of its players had earlier turned out for India A against Sri Lanka A and were ready. When the series commenced with the first Test at picturesque Galle, India led from the front and won by 165 runs to secure a 1-0 lead. Devdutt Padikkal’s 167 and 44 led the run charts and most importantly it also meant that the critical number three spot in the batting order had found an apt occupant for now. This is the same position that in the past had featured pedigreed men such as Dilip Vengsarkar, Rahul Dravid and Cheteshwar Pujara. Left-arm spinner Manav Suthar too did well and his classical mode is a throwback to a gentle past. Sri Lanka’s brief resistance hinged on Sonal Dinusha, who registered a ton. Soon he would become an immovable personality at the batting crease and India learnt it the hard way at Colombo. His twin hundreds helped Sri Lanka erase the ignominy of suffering a follow-on and also survive a tense final day to wrest a draw. The conclusion felt like a victory for the host and India is now placed in a must-win corner in its future Tests.

In his Independence day address this year, Prime Minister Narendra Modi declared that his government had eliminated the threat of armed Naxals/Maoists, but added that ‘*dimaagi*’ Naxals (brainy Naxals) remain. These dangerous individuals, he said, had been elevated to policy advisers by his predecessors. Now, they look for opportunities to ‘drag society onto the wrong path’ and ‘steer the nation’s youth’ away from the ‘mainstream effort’ to turn India into ‘a developed nation.’ He asked Indian citizens to ‘identify and isolate’ such individuals among them.

Defining the enemy

Is Mr. Modi the first leader of a democratic nation to declare thoughts to be crimes, without resort to innuendo or euphemism, in a formal address to the nation? A search for other instances came up empty.

But has he not used terms such as ‘urban Naxal’ before? Is ‘*dimaagi*’ Naxal’ any different? I believe it is a significant escalation.

First, while he has used the term ‘urban Naxal’ in campaign speeches and in Parliament, he has not previously used it in an Independence Day address to the nation.

Second, ‘urban’ implies an alleged connection to ‘rural’ Naxals: urban individuals are alleged to be facilitating crimes attributed to Maoist insurgents. The actual charges may be fabricated, and individuals might in fact be criminalised for their ideology, that is, for thought crimes. But the government did not admit this. In this case however, Mr. Modi declared the end of rural Naxals, and then formulated the category of ‘*dimaagi*’ Naxals’. It is their ‘*dimaag*’ alone, cut off from any alleged ties to armed Maoist insurgents, that he declares to be criminal.

Had Mr Modi chosen to say ‘Naxali *dimaag*’ or ‘Naxali *soch*’ (thinking), it might be taken to mean Maoist ideology. But ‘*dimaagi*’ Naxal’ does not identify a specific ideology as dangerous.

‘*Dimaag*’ itself is the deadly weapon. In Hindi/Urdu, *dimaag* is used to mean the brain, head, mind, consciousness, intellect, and intelligence. To use your *dimaag* is to ‘use your head’ – that is, to think out of the box, to reason, to think critically, to use your intelligence for resourceful problem-solving.

Mr. Modi is notorious for asking Indians to identify terrorists by what they wear - ‘*kapde se pehchano*’ (Identify/judge someone by their clothes) - a dog whistle for Muslims wearing lungis, skullcaps or hijabs. Now, he is saying ‘*dimaag se pehchano*’ – identify anti-nationals by how they think.

Operation Demonise *Dimaag* began a decade



Kavita Krishnan

Author of
‘De-democratisation,
A Global Story: Script,
Actors, Enablers’

ago in 2016, with the attempt to incite hatred and violence against Jawaharlal Nehru University students and teachers. For six years the regime has declared student protesters (such as Umar Khalid, Sharjeel Imam, Gulfisha Fatima, Natasha Narwal, Devangana Kalita) to be terrorists, without a trial, without much push-back from the judiciary and the press. Emboldened, it deployed the same tactic against students protesting examination paper leaks, calling them ‘*dehshatgarh*’ (terrorists). But stretched to such lengths, this tactic snapped – and backfired. It ‘leaked’ the key to the regime’s propaganda codes. All of a sudden, all too many people could see the pattern plainly. The government rewarded mindless obedience, reverence and adulation for Power. Apply your mind, your *dimaag*, to demand democratic accountability from Power, and it would “identify and isolate” you as a terrorist, an *andolanjeevi* (parasite feeding on protests), a cockroach.

Echoes of an old template

The timing is telling. Mr Modi is attacking *Dimaag* when he is still smarting from his debacle at the hands of young students armed only with wit and imagination. He wants to prevent a recurrence. Ironically, since he calls his critics ‘Naxals’ (Maoists), he seems to be embracing the Chinese template for thought crimes.

A Chinese Communist Party memorandum, of 2013, warns that Internet forums, “lectures, seminars, university classrooms, class discussion forums, civilian study groups” as well as “open letters and... petition-signings to vocalise requests for political reforms, improvement of human rights” represent a threat to the nation. Why? Because “if we allow any of these ideas to spread, they will disturb people’s existing consensus on important issues like which flag to raise, which road to take, which goals to pursue”.

That is what the student protests did: demolish Mr. Modi’s claim to represent a monolithic popular consensus, challenged only by a tiny gang of unpopular critics. That consensus must be restored.

Mr. Modi identified ‘*dimaagi*’ Naxals’ as the foremost internal threat to national security. Is his plan for “a huge voluntary force of civil defence” intended to deal with them?

The examples Mr. Modi cites are unconvincing. Defending refineries from aerial bombardment and banks from cyber attacks cannot be left to ‘civilian volunteers’ – these would need enhanced air defence and cyber-security systems comprising experts. We already have the Civil Defence Act 1968 and the Home Guards to organise civilians for non-combat roles. Is Mr.

The new
labelling is an
escalation of
the
government’s
attitude
towards dissent
and democracy

Nepal’s agony, the Himalayan warning to India

Will India learn now at least? Will it let Nepal speak to India through its agony what India has refused to hear?

The Himalaya are not a series of silos – Afghanistan Hindu Kush Himalaya, Pakistan Himalaya, Indian Himalaya, Nepal Himalaya, the Himalaya in Tibet-China, Bhutan. To employ a powerful term I have heard Vadodara-based painter Gulam Mohammed Sheikh use for the Elephanta Caves, the Himalaya are one living rock, silently, broodingly, tense with seismic voltages, glacial stirrings and geological turbulence.

And they spell their uncoded thought in swipes no one can foretell. When, where exactly, with what ferocity, no one knows. And what disasters may radiate from them – through rivers plucked from their courses, rockfalls and landslides depositing mud and silt, turning human habitations into rubble and fertile farms into slime – no one can precisely envision.

Ask those who have heard from their parents and grandparents of the Nepal-Bihar earthquake of 1934 or the Assam temblor of 1950. They will speak of the nightmare.

The question of preparedness

The world has been told – India has specifically been warned – by seismologists of an impending earthquake of humungous scale with the potential of a cataclysm across a great swathe of northern India which lies under the quake-shadow of the Himalaya. It is not as if India’s government has declined to heed the warning. It has done much, as its disaster management agencies will rightly assure us, to be alert to the risk.

But after 26/8 what we need to ask and know is: should what happened in upper Nepal have



Gopalkrishna Gandhi

Former administrator
who has held
diplomatic and
constitutional offices

One living rock,
shared by
nations, makes
its dangers a
shared concern
for all

happened in lower Nepal, and even lower than that, would our ‘preparedness’ have sufficed to save riverside habitations from instant death?

More pertinently, we need to ask and know whether the absolutely fearsome phenomenon of global warming triggered GLOFs (or Glacial Lake Outburst Floods), has led authorities to warn people living in potential GLOF-affected areas in India of the danger they face and advised them on how to face it.

We are, let us face it, in seismic, glacial, climatological and geological innocence.

By ‘we’ I mean we the people of India. Our earth scientists know it all but their *jnana* is clasped tight in their *acharya-mushiti-s* (‘knowledge kept in the teacher’s fist’).

What happened in Nepal on that stricken Wednesday is yet to be fully appraised. We will soon enough know whether it was an earthquake that caused the GLOF, or whether the GLOF resulted in the earth quaking and waterbodies swelling as they never have before.

Whatever happened, India must learn

Be the sequence as it may, the following lessons scream to be learnt by India.

First, the Himalaya, held sacred since memory has served, gestate ‘sure-shot’ danger.

Second, these dangers can now no longer be left to be unravelled in seminars and technical papers.

Third, they have to be made known on a war footing to us, the clear potential victims.

Fourth, and not just made known as in increasing our knowledge but made known as in making us part of a new safeguarding.

Fifth, our scholar-diplomat Shyam Saran has, in two timely and telling articles in *The Tribune* (“China’s hydel project bodes ill for India”, July 14, 2026) and *The Indian Express* (“From Nepal to

Modi’s proposal inspired by his ideological gurus from a century ago?

In 1931, Dr. B.S. Moonje, Hindu Mahasabha leader and close associate of Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) founder K.B. Hedgewar, visited Italy to meet the fascist leader Benito Mussolini. Mussolini was notorious for civilian militias such as the ‘Voluntary Militia for National Security’, colloquially known as the Blackshirts, which unleashed violent terror against political rivals, union leaders, journalists and writers. In 1934, Moonje and Hedgewar met to discuss the need for a Hindu-supremacist militia to achieve the ‘ideal’ of “a Hindu as a dictator... like Mussolini or Hitler of the present day Italy and Germany”. In 1935, Moonje explained that his aim was to also militarise Hindu society so as to completely choke off any other expressions of social life – “There will thus be no longer any distinction between the citizen and the soldier, between the civilian and the man in uniform.”

In 1939, Moonje expressed the hope that the RSS “might be useful and handy” in the task of preparing such a Hindu-supremacist militia. Who would it fight? Not so much the British Raj or potential Japanese invaders, but “internal enemies” – i.e., Muslims and the Congress wing of the freedom struggle. Moonje specifically visualised a conflict between “the mutually antagonistic and clashing ideologies”, i.e., between “the Rifle” (symbolising the Hindutva militia) and “the Charka” (symbolising Gandhi). Nearly a decade later, Nathuram Godse wielded the Rifle that killed Gandhi.

The road ahead

Today, a woman who proudly declared herself a ‘fan of Godse’ and said the very name ‘Gandhi’ is like a ‘*gaali*’ (a swear word), has been elevated to the leadership of the Bharatiya Janata Party’s social media cell. As has a man who used foul abuse against Congress Parliamentary Party chairperson Sonia Gandhi, and the “b****y voting right” for Muslims and oppressed castes as the “root cause” of India’s problems. Meanwhile, online and offline pro-Modi mobs as well as police are hounding student protesters, especially girls and women. The pretext is that the students, as a last resort, raised profane slogans at Mr. Modi himself, which turned out to be the only thing to move him to remove his corrupt Minister.

Will these mobs, together with the moral policing mobs and the anti-Muslim lynch mobs, be elevated to the ranks of Mr. Modi’s ‘civilian defence force’? This is a real danger, given that his supporters believe he is the ‘Hindu Hitler’ of Moonje’s and Hedgewar’s dreams.

Uttarakhand and China, the mountains are warning us”, August 28, 2026), explained how China’s construction of Medog, the world’s largest hydropower project, at the great bend of the Brahmaputra river just across the border and very close to the Paizhen Fault, could (should there be a major earthquake in the project’s vicinity), cause a massive discharge of floodwaters and debris into India’s northeast. India’s salutary initiatives to bring about a measure of mature civility on the borders with China must now include frankness about the ferocious danger that Medog poses.

Sixth, an urgent review of India’s own built hazards such as dams and reactors in the high risk zones followed by the dismantling of the real ‘baddies’ can no longer be postponed.

Seventh, and no less difficult but no less important, a calibrated but time-bound decongestion of human agglomerations in high-risk zones.

Eighth, if surgical strikes can be used with precision and without excesses against an external enemy to good effect, their civilian equivalent should be deployed to disable that which, though intended for our well-being, has become a danger.

Progress and danger

Marjorie Sykes was a British devotee of India, in the tradition of C.F. Andrews, Verrier Elwin and J.B.S. Haldane. I once heard her say with passion: “Dams are a damnation.” All dams may not be, but some, depending on their location, are. Likewise, some reactors can become rakshasas. And some commercial behemoths, predatory.

A big and great nation can learn from the experience of a small neighbour. Especially when both are perched on the same living rock that threatens to turn into a mass grave.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Uphold Bar standards

Lawyers have played a significant role in modern India, in shaping our society and polity, particularly during the freedom struggle and after Independence (Front page, “Not a good sign if a Bar Council loses respect: SC judge”, August 30). Many stalwarts have graced the higher judiciary, conducted themselves with the utmost dignity, upheld professional values, and brought respect to the Bar. The Bar Council of India has also largely done well in regulating the legal profession and maintaining

professional standards. However, recent developments have caused dismay within the legal community and beyond. The widely criticised decision directing the State Bar Councils to halt the enrolment of the NALSAR 2026 batch, and its subsequent reversal, have cast the Bar Council of India in a poor light. The call by Supreme Court judge Justice B.V. Nagarathna urging the Bar Councils to “introspect on their role and importance in upholding professional ethics, morality and professional

competence” is timely. The Bar Councils should take note of this.

Kosaraju Chandramouli,
Hyderabad

No country above the law

If Russia’s actions against Ukraine and Iran’s actions against Kuwait are condemned, why should similar conduct by the United States be treated differently? Venezuela is a sovereign nation, not an American colony whose natural resources can be controlled at Washington’s will. The reported U.S. control over

Venezuelan oil raises serious questions about national sovereignty and international law. The United Nations appears to become a “sleeping beauty” whenever a powerful nation acts with impunity. International law must apply equally to every country; no nation should

be above it. Otherwise, global institutions risk encouraging dictators who believe that power makes them untouchable.

T. Kailash Ditya,
Hyderabad

The spirit of Madras
The Hindu and the citizens of Chennai deserve praise

Corrections & Clarifications

In an article, “The long wait for a woman Minister in Karnataka” (Opinion page – ‘State of Play’, August 13, 2026), a sentence read: “Since then, the share has fluctuated, with the 1972 election seeing not even a single woman elected to the Assembly out of the 28 who contested.” It should have said, “Since then, the share has fluctuated from election to election.”

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for making Madras Day a vibrant tribute to the city’s heritage. From soul-stirring music, dance and food festivals to heritage walks, photographic exhibitions and quizzes, this collaborative initiative beautifully brings together history and community while proudly showcasing the timeless charm and rich legacy of Madras to the world.

T.S. Karthik,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Rehabilitation centres in Mizoram for drug addicts

48 Mizoram has 48 centres and homes providing care and rehabilitation services to 5,224 people affected by drug addiction, officials said on Sunday. The State government provided ₹42 lakh as financial assistance to these centres and homes. PTI

Number of doctors to be recruited by Himachal govt.

650 Speaking at the inauguration of a health camp, Himachal Pradesh CM Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu said that the government is going to recruit 300 medical officers, 200 specialist doctors and 150 super-specialist doctors. PTI

Heat-related deaths seen in Austria in June and July

646 Austria saw its highest-ever recorded number of heat-related deaths this June and July, the country's health agency said on Sunday. The AGES agency said those two months saw 646 heat-related deaths. APF

Amount sanctioned by J&K govt. to repair migrant flats

82 in ₹ crore. The Jammu and Kashmir government has approved a ₹82.45-crore repair project for 5,000 flats across Jammu's migrant camps. Public Works Department officials said that repair and renovation would be taken up soon. PTI

People aboard ferry that capsized off coast of northern Cyprus

267 At least seven people have died after a ferry carrying at least 267 passengers and crew capsized off the coast of northern Cyprus on Sunday, Turkish media reported. AP
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OBC creamy layer and the income test

Why is the Centre finding the ruling difficult to implement? What exactly did the Supreme Court rule on the creamy layer? Why is the Centre seeking clarification? What are its concerns over implementing the ruling? What happens next in the creamy layer case?

EXPLAINER

Abhinay Lakshman

The story so far:

The Supreme Court has said it will consider setting up a Bench to hear the Centre's application seeking clarification over its March 11 judgment on the income test component of the OBC creamy layer exclusion criteria. Retrospectively implementing the judgment on the income/wealth test for OBC creamy layer determination is “extremely difficult” and will cause a “cascading effect” in the settled services from 2012 till now, with the impact extending to “all categories, including the Unreserved category”, the Centre said in a batch of applications.

Why does the Centre call the ruling ‘extremely difficult’ to implement?

The Supreme Court on March 11 delivered its judgment in a batch of cases pending for close to a decade, relating to how the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) should interpret the crucial income/wealth test, which is one of the layers through which the “creamy layer” (or relatively socially and economically forward) among the Other Backward Classes communities is excluded from availing the benefit of reservation.

The cases that eventually came before the court involved claims by at least 50 OBC candidates who had appeared in Civil Services Examinations (CSE) since 2015 and were excluded from consideration for an OBC-reserved post after the DoPT classified them as part of the creamy layer solely based on their parents’ income.

The Supreme Court found that the DoPT was incorrectly applying the income test for this category of OBC candidates and directed the government to create supernumerary posts for the OBC candidates to whom the income test had been applied with what it called “hostile discrimination,” and allot them services according to their ranks in their respective CSE years.

What are the criteria for exclusion?

The creamy layer concept among OBCs emerged from the Supreme Court’s 1992 ruling in the *Indra Sawhney* case, which paved the way for the implementation of OBC reservations. The idea was to exclude OBC candidates whose families had accumulated social and economic privileges over the years from the benefits of reservation. Such candidates came to be described as belonging to the “creamy layer”.

To clarify which categories of OBC candidates would fall under the creamy layer, the DoPT issued an Office Memorandum [(OM), a guiding charter] in September 1993, laying down the criteria for exclusion.

The OM prescribed several categories of exclusion, including children of senior constitutional, judicial, government and armed forces officers.

Besides this, the DoPT also prescribed a crucial income or wealth test, applicable to people in the salaried professional class or engaged in trade; people holding plantations, vacant land and/or buildings in urban areas; and people whose parents held posts in Central or State PSUs where the equivalence of these posts with government service posts had not yet been established. It is this last category, that is, children of parents holding posts in Central or State PSUs or in private employment, that the court delivered its March 11 judgment.



GETTY IMAGES

What was the problem with the 1993 OM and 2004 letter?

Under the 1993 DoPT OM on the income/wealth test for OBC reservations, a candidate would be considered part of the creamy layer if their parents’ gross family income exceeded the prescribed limit for three consecutive years, or if they possessed wealth above the exemption limit prescribed under the Wealth Tax Act, 1957. The income limit, which was ₹1 lakh when the 1993 OM was issued, was revised several times and now stands at ₹8 lakh, with the last revision having come in 2017. Importantly, the 1993 DoPT OM specified that income from salaries and agricultural land should be excluded when applying the income/wealth test, with income from other sources such as property, business, or capital gains being considered.

However, in October 2004, the DoPT issued a letter meant to clarify issues that had arisen in interpreting the 1993 OM. In paragraph 9 of this letter, the DoPT took up the issue of how to calculate income for the income/wealth test for OBCs whose parents were in Central or State PSUs where equivalence of posts had not yet been established. The DoPT seemed to suggest that income from salaries was to be counted to determine if the income was above the prescribed threshold for three consecutive years. The threshold was subsequently revised to ₹8 lakh per year in 2017.

In the 2026 ruling, the Division Bench noted that until the government establishes equivalence between the posts of Central or State PSUs and government services, the income/wealth test must continue to apply equally.

How did the Supreme Court interpret the income test?

The March 11 *Union of India vs Rohith Nathan* judgment said that OBC candidates whose parents work in PSUs or the private sector, where the government has yet to establish equivalence of posts with government services, cannot be treated differently from OBC candidates in other categories under the creamy layer exclusion criteria.

Significantly, the Supreme Court ruled that the income/wealth test component of the exclusion exercise must be seen and operated as a “residual filter”, adding that salaries and agricultural incomes had been consciously left out while applying this test under the 1993 OM. The court found that while the 1993 OM was clear about excluding income from salaries from the calculation of the income/wealth test, the 2004 letter appeared to call for its inclusion in circumstances that were

not clearly specified.

The court went on to note that the interpretation of the 1993 OM, read with the 2004 letter, had led to “hostile discrimination” between the children of those in government service and those in PSUs or private employment.

Without establishing equivalence of posts, the income test, including salaries, was being applied to rule out OBC candidates whose parents were not in government service, while OBC candidates whose parents were in government service were being subjected to a test that did not include salaries. This is what the court had described as “hostile discrimination”.

The court said, “Treating the children of those employed in PSUs or private employment, etc., as being excluded from the benefit of reservation only on the basis of their income derived from salaries, and without reference to their posts (whether Group A or B, or Group C or D) would certainly lead to hostile discrimination between parties who are similarly placed and would amount to equals being treated unequally.”

The court had directed the Centre to implement this reading of the income test within six months by creating supernumerary posts for the petitioners, who were OBC candidates in the Civil Services Examinations and had been excluded from the creamy layer on account of their parents’ salaries alone. The parents were working in public sector undertakings or the private sector.

Did the Centre try to implement the Supreme Court’s directions?

The Supreme Court’s ruling in the *Rohith Nathan* case was a watershed moment for this category of OBCs, who had said that the issue had been pending for more than a decade. As per the Supreme Court’s direction, the Union government was supposed to issue further instructions in pursuance of the court’s reading of the income test component – on how the supernumerary posts must be created and how the existing strength of the services must be adjusted to accommodate them.

According to government records, the Union Ministry of Personnel, Pensions and Public Grievances wrote to the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment on June 3, seeking advice on implementing the directions of the *Rohith Nathan* judgment. The Personnel Ministry told the Social Justice Secretary that the Allocation of Business Rules provide for the Social Justice Ministry to formulate policy on reservations and that it was therefore seeking

“clarification/action” in this regard. The Personnel Ministry further sought “advice on instructions to be adopted or notified” by the DoPT.

As of August 19, the Centre’s position before the Central Administrative Tribunal in a matter identical to that of the aggrieved OBC candidates in the *Rohith Nathan* case was that it was in the process of implementing the March 11 judgment.

However, a few days later, the DoPT filed an application highlighting why it was seemingly impossible to follow the Supreme Court’s directions and the issues that were arising in implementing them retrospectively. In this application, the Centre said that despite its efforts to create the supernumerary posts as called for in the *Rohith Nathan* judgment, it was facing an increasing number of claims for adjustment, issues of seniority arising from such adjustments, and concerns that even this exercise could be “unfair” to a different category of OBC candidates and candidates of “all categories, including the unreserved category”.

The Centre noted that since the March 11 judgment, 22 other judgments have been issued by courts applying the principles laid out in *Rohith Nathan*. In addition, the DoPT said that 12 new cases have been filed seeking reconsideration of OBC non-creamy layer status under the Rohith Nathan principles, by candidates who had not previously approached the courts.

However, OBC candidates who spoke to *The Hindu* argued that the Centre’s reluctance to implement the directions does not appear to make sense. These candidates have asked why the DoPT had not mentioned these larger issues with implementation earlier.

These candidates have noted that the older reading of the income test – the one that the court said practised “hostile discrimination” – was being applied only by the DoPT, and that too arbitrarily.

What happens next?

Along with the application that the DoPT has filed setting out the difficulties it was facing in implementing the *Rohith Nathan* judgment’s directions, especially retrospectively, the Union government had filed a separate application, seeking that it be allowed to continue allotting services as per the old reading of the income test for CSE 2025 candidates, and seeking clarification on how to implement the directions. The Centre said that more than 950 CSE 2025 candidates were about to start their Foundation Course and that they had been recommended based on the old reading of the income test.

The DoPT argued, in this application, that the retrospective application of the judgment was specifically running into the issues mentioned above.

The Supreme Court has now said it will consider setting up a Bench to hear the Centre’s request for clarification on how to implement its directions and its request to allow the allotment of services to CSE 2025 candidates to continue as settled for the time being.

However, in the other application filed along with this, the Centre has asked for clarification on how to implement the direction overall. It has further argued that there might be some value in including income from salaries, as in some cases it might be the “sole intelligible differentia” between two OBC candidates from “similar social backgrounds”. It has also argued that, in the absence of salary consideration, some cases might lead to OBC candidates with parents earning up to ₹1 crore being considered non-creamy layer.

Now, the question is: how far will the Supreme Court’s March 11 verdict reach?

THE GIST

The Supreme Court’s March 11 ruling held that salary income should not be used to exclude OBC candidates from the creamy layer where their parents work in PSUs or private employment without established equivalence of posts with government service.

The Centre says retrospective implementation could have a ‘cascading effect’ on settled services, while triggering fresh claims from candidates who were previously denied OBC non-creamy-layer status.

The Supreme Court will consider setting up a Bench to hear the Centre’s plea for clarification on implementing the ruling, including its application to CSE 2025 candidates.

CACHE



Even without Meta's new controls, parents and educators can work with children to fight social media addiction. REUTERS

Can Meta’s safety controls make Facebook and Instagram less addictive for teens?

Meta has agreed to an \$18-billion settlement with U.S. states and will introduce stricter controls for teen users; but enforcing these safeguards could prove difficult as children can evade age checks, while the measures also raise concerns over privacy and the role of rival platforms

Sahana Venugopal

The story so far: On August 26, Meta agreed to an approximately \$18 billion settlement with dozens of U.S. states in annual instalments over 10 years, and announced stricter controls in its apps for teen users. The settlement is the culmination of a lawsuit brought by California and 28 other U.S. states alleging that Facebook and Instagram are harmful for children and that they illegally collect personal data. While several parents and child health advocates welcomed the new child protection controls, enforcing them will be a lot more challenging.

What child protections is Meta rolling out? The social media giant is both rolling out new features and building on existing features designed to create a safer and less addictive experience for Facebook and Instagram users under 18. These measures are set to automatically apply in participating U.S. states and territories. 52 attorneys general covering U.S. states, territories, and the District of Columbia have joined the agreement.

Arguably, the biggest win for parents and the biggest concession by Meta is a default two-hour daily time limit across Facebook and Instagram. Teens can only turn this off with a parent's permission. Furthermore, a 'Night Mode' will block app users between 12 AM and 6 AM, so teens cannot post or view their Feed, Stories, Reels, or the Explore section. Similarly, the School Mode between 8 AM

and 3 PM will mute notifications by default. However, these limits do not apply to direct messages (DMs). Teens are set to receive multiple prompts after every 15 minutes of continuous screen time on Facebook/Instagram, apart from prompts that come after their total daily usage reaches 60 minutes and 90 minutes. To directly address addictive video features, Meta is giving teens (and their parents) the ability to choose a non-algorithmic feed as their default, as well as the ability to turn off Autoplay. As for steps to combat unhealthy comparisons and anxiety over appearances and popularity, teen users will no longer see the number of likes and reactions on posts by default. Meta is also expanding its policy to block teens from using "extreme makeup filters," adding to a previous block against cosmetic surgery filters for teens. Meta reaffirmed its commitment to strengthening existing controls in order to catch underage account users, as well as teens falsely entering adult birthdays. The company claimed it will continue placing teens into private accounts on Instagram and activating private default settings on Facebook, apart from restricting "potentially suspicious adults" from reaching out to them. Meta also said it would encourage parents to set up its supervision tools, and give them new controls and insights.

Can these safety controls be effectively enforced? This is the crux of the matter. Safety controls for teens work only as well as the technology that verifies users' ages and

detects rule-breakers. Take Australia, for example; the country was the first to enforce a strict blanket ban on social media for children under 16. While many parents lauded the idea and Meta reported this month that it removed over 750,000 accounts that it suspected were held by under-16s, a study by the University of Newcastle there reported that the ban did not appear to have significantly impacted under-16s who were using social media. As other platforms and administrations explore age restrictions, critics have pointed out how easily children can fake their ages – even in video selfies and live camera tests. What's more, these data collection tactics raise additional questions about how children's private information is being harvested. In its settlement announcement, Meta pointed out that all platforms – and not just its apps – should have teen safety measures in place to prevent children from moving to less restricted apps. So as to not be held back in isolation, Meta called on rival social media apps YouTube and TikTok to adopt the "new standard." Meta stated that around 30% of its settlement, or \$5.3 billion, would be released only after rival apps YouTube and TikTok implement similar controls and pay a stipulated amount of money. To sweeten the deal, Meta said that if industry peers signed the agreement, it would further reduce the daily limit to one hour per app and expand night mode limits. In other words, this increases the incentive for U.S. regulators to also bring Meta's rivals in line with the new policies. Separately, the social media giant said it supported laws requiring app stores to

verify users' age and obtain parental approval before teens can download an app. This shifts the responsibility of age verification to companies such as Apple and Google. **How can parents elsewhere make Facebook, Instagram less addictive?** Even without Meta's new controls, parents and educators can work with children to fight social media addiction. Most smartphones come with built-in parental controls that allow adults to set time limits for individual apps, as well as curtail overall device use. Furthermore, many of Meta's existing safety controls – such as Teen Accounts on Instagram – can be used by children across borders who enter their ages correctly. For more advanced settings, adults can research and download parental control apps that allow them to set up different usage limits for multiple children and monitor their activity remotely. Some apps allow parents to remotely lock devices and apps during sleeping hours and/or school hours. Meanwhile, teachers can communicate with their students via email, or send alerts through non-addictive digital forums during daytime hours. Students should be strongly discouraged from conducting school assignments or group projects via social media apps. Enabling parental controls for teen social media users is a constantly evolving challenge. After all, these young internet and AI-native users are often more tech-savvy than the very adults trying to restrict their time online

THE DAILY QUIZ

A quiz on Malaysia which is celebrating its Independence Day on August 31

V.V. Ramanan

QUESTION 1 Malaysians celebrate 'Hari Merdeka' on August 31 to commemorate the independence of the Federation of Malaya from British rule. On what date do they celebrate Malaysia Day, which marks the formation of Malaysia?

QUESTION 2 What is the monarch, who is elected from nine hereditary Malay Rulers for a five-year term, called and who is the present ruler?

QUESTION 3 If the Indian currency notes carry the image of Mahatma Gandhi, whose portrait is

featured on the Malaysian Ringgit?

QUESTION 4 Name the famous archipelago with 99 islands and geological formations that became Malaysia's first UNESCO Global Geopark.

QUESTION 5 Name the Malaysian-born actress who became the first Asian woman to win the Best Actress Oscar in 2023.

QUESTION 6 In which sport did Nicol David win a record eight World Open titles between 2005 and 2014?

QUESTION 7 Which Bornean primate is known for its large, pendulous nose in males?



Visual Question: Name the place where this famous statue of Lord Muruga is located. AFP

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1. In politics, he was the first PM of his newly independent country while she became the first woman President of the UN General Assembly in 1953. Name the famous siblings. **Ans: Jawaharlal Nehru and Vijayalakshmi Pandit** 2. This famous 1807 work that narrated the works of a famous English playwright was authored by a brother-sister duo. Name them and the work. **Ans: Charles and Mary Lamb's 'Tales of Shakespeare'** 3. According to historians, Ptolemy XIII and Ptolemy XIV were consorts and ruled alongside their sister, who is considerably more famous and legendary than the two men. Name her. **Ans: Cleopatra** 4. In later Ramayana traditions, what was the name of Rama's elder sister. **Ans: Shanta, wife of Rishyasyringa** 5. Name the Russian siblings who have not only won titles at a tennis Major but are the only brother and sister to reach the No.1 ranking in singles. **Ans: Marat Safin and Dinara Safina** 6. The National Bravery awards given by the Indian government are named after two teenagers who were murdered in 1978. Name the two. **Ans: Geeta and Sanjay Chopra** 7. In Greek myth, name the twins born to Zeus and Leto. **Ans: Apollo and Artemis** Visual: Name these siblings who have also won Oscars apart from the Grammys and other leading awards. **Ans: Billie Eilish and Finneas O'Connell** **Early Birds:** Siddhartha Viswanathan | Tamal Biswas | Sukdev Shet | Piyali Tuli | Arun Kumar Singh



KNOW YOUR ENGLISH

No amount of rest could ease her fatigue

The children were tired after their two-hour trek

S. Upendran

What is the difference between 'fatigue' and 'tired'? (S Jayanthi, Mysore) There is a tendency among some people to use the two words interchangeably – especially in informal contexts. It is wrong to do so. Of the two, 'tired' is the more frequently used. When we say we are tired, what we mean is that we are running low on energy. We all get tired from time to time – for example, after playing a couple of sets of tennis, after a long day's work, etc. We don't panic when this happens because we know why we are tired. We can overcome our tiredness either by eating something that will give us the energy back or by getting some rest - a good night's sleep, perhaps! The lack of energy that we experience when we are tired is only temporary. *The children were extremely tired after trekking for two hours. You look very tired. Get some rest before tomorrow's big game.*

It is possible for one to be both physically and mentally tired. 'Fatigue' is a little more serious than being tired. Unlike 'tired', it is not a temporary phenomenon. One can feel fatigued for days together; it is long-lasting, and what is more alarming is that we may not always know the cause. It could be your diabetes or your heart condition that leaves you fatigued. No amount of rest helps in the recovery, and the constant tiredness often prevents you from doing your work. It interferes with your daily routine. This constant fatigue is your body's way of telling you that something is wrong. *Is something wrong? You've been looking fatigued for a week now.* The word consists of two syllables; the 'a' in the first sounds like the 'a' in 'china', while the following 'i' is like the 'ee' in 'fee', 'bee' and 'see'. The word is pronounced 'fe-TEEG' with the stress on the second syllable.

Why do we say 'litter of puppies' and 'litter of kittens'? (L Rachna, Secunderabad) Today, when we hear the word 'litter', the first thing that comes to mind is the trash we see everywhere in our cities. This meaning of the word, however, came much later. 'Litter' comes from the Latin 'lectus' meaning 'bed', and it was originally used to refer to the portable chair or bed carried on poles – in the past, royals like Julius Caesar and Cleopatra used to be carried from one place to another in these. With the passage of time, the meaning of the word took on a broader meaning, and soon 'litter' began to be used to refer to any kind of bed – including the layer of straw that owners sometimes spread on the floor when their pet cat or dog was ready to give birth. It was not long after that the focus changed from the bed to the newborn that were lying on the bed. The animals born to the same mother around the same time began to be called a litter. The term is normally used with animals which give birth to several offspring – dogs, cats, pigs, etc. *Manisha's dog gave birth to a litter of seven puppies.* upendrankye@gmail.com

Word of the day

Compeer: a person who is of equal standing with another in a group

Synonyms: associate, colleague, accomplice, peer

Usage: She was respected by her compeers for her expertise.

Pronunciation: newsth.live/compeer

International Phonetic Alphabet: /kɒmpɪə/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

Which Nifty is right for you?

Vaishali R. Venkat

Imagine you decide to invest in equity via an index fund. But which market are you actually buying? The 50 biggest firms? The next 50 waiting in the wings? Or, a much broader basket of 500 firms? All three are called Nifty indices, but they can give your money very different rides. So, it's worth asking a simple question: Which one to choose?

It matters because choosing an index fund is not simply a question of picking the one with more number of firms or the one with 'bluechips'. Instead, you are choosing between how much of the market to own and where that exposure comes from.

Nifty 50
The Nifty 50 may give you exposure to 50 large firms but as of July 31, 2026 financial services alone accounted for 36.18%, healthcare 4.82% and power just 2.63% of the index. So, the real question for an investor is: Do you want the largest firms, the next tier of firms, a broader slice of market or a sector mix you are comfortable with?

What if you don't want to bet on which part of the market will win? The Nifty 50 gives you exposure to 50 of the market's largest firms. So, for an investor who wants to keep equity investing simple, it can be a 'perfectly reasonable' one-index approach. But there is an important question hiding beneath: are you comfortable owning mainly the firms that have already turned the market's biggest or also firms that could become tomorrow's 'giants'? That is where the Nifty Next 50 enters the picture.

Nifty Next 50
If the Nifty 50 represents the established 'giants', the Nifty Next 50 takes you one step down the ladder, bringing in the next 50 companies outside the Nifty 50. That makes it an interesting middle ground: you are still investing in relatively large companies but moving beyond the market's biggest names. For an investor who feels the Nifty 50 is too concentrated in today's 'giants' but who does not want to straddle across the entire market, the Next 50 offers a different proposition. The next query is whether you want exposure to the next set of companies in the market-cap hierarchy or prefer the wider spread offered by the Nifty 500.

Nifty 500
What if you don't want to pick a winner? This is where the Nifty 500 changes the scenario altogether. Instead of deciding whether the market's biggest companies or the next tier will do better, you are spreading your exposure much further across the Indian equity market. That can appeal to an investor who does not want to make a call on which segment of the market will lead over the next 10 or 20 years.

The trade-off is equally important: you are also accepting exposure to companies beyond the large-cap universe, which can make the ride different from a Nifty 50 fund. In simple terms, Nifty 50 asks you to back the 'giants'; Nifty Next 50 gives you the 'climbers'; Nifty 500 lets you own a much larger part of the race.

Which one to choose?
There is no single universally "best" index. However, history offers a useful reality check: diversification does not automatically mean lower risk. In NSE Indices' February 2026 Riskometer assessment, all three indices were classified as "Very High" risk, but the scores rose from 5.33 for Nifty 50 to 5.43 for Nifty Next 50 and 5.60 for Nifty 500.

So, while Nifty 500 gives you a much wider slice of the market, it has not been the least risky of the three by this measure. The choice, therefore, is less about finding a "safe" index and more about deciding how much market breadth and volatility you are prepared to accept.

(The writer is an NISM & CRISIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM's Research Analyst module)



ILLUSTRATION: SAAI

Why gold should form 10% of investment portfolio

Most investors think of portfolio in terms of equity and fixed income but buying gold is not a speculative add-on, it is a structural building block of a well-constructed portfolio

SHINES ABOVE REST

Joydeep Sen

Most investors think of portfolio in terms of equity and fixed income. Gold is an afterthought. That approach misses the point. Gold deserves a deliberate, planned allocation of about 10% of every portfolio and here is why.

A diversifier, not a bet
Long-term data shows gold behaves differently from equity and fixed income in most situations. When equity markets are under stress, gold tends to hold up or even gain. When bond yields rise sharply on inflation worries, gold does well since it is seen as a hedge against currency depreciation. This is the essence of diversification - you don't want all assets moving in the same direction at the same time.

If you run a portfolio with equity and fixed income and allocate 10% to gold, the math works out in your favour as the overall portfolio volatility drops as gold price movements are not synchronised with the other two asset classes. Risk-adjusted or volatility-adjusted return improves. This is how portfolio construction works when you combine assets that do not move in lockstep. You are adding gold as it smoothens the ride.

Global central banks have been briskly adding

Global central banks have been briskly adding gold to reserves with the driving force being the geopolitical environment

gold to reserves.

Central bank buying
Sanctions, trade tensions and a more fragmented world order have made many central banks wary of holding all reserves in U.S. Treasuries. Gold held within a country's own vaults does not carry counterparty risk the way a government bond does. This shift by central banks has been one of the steadiest sources of demand for gold over the past four years.

No trend breaking
Gold has corrected meaningfully from a peak earlier this year. Prices had run up too far too quickly, and some of that froth had to come off. What matters more is if the long-term uptrend is intact. Chartists tracking gold have a technical support line and even after this correction, that line has not been broken. A correction within an intact uptrend is very different from a trend reversal.

Rupee depreciation
Gold price is quoted in U.S. dollars and set daily by the London Bullion Market Association. The price in India is that global dollar

Gold has a inverse relationship with the U.S. dollar (USD). When the USD strengthens, gold in dollar terms tends to soften and vice versa.

price converted into rupees. Over the long run, the rupee had depreciated against the dollar and is likely to continue so. Every time the rupee weakens, it adds to rupee-denominated return from gold over and above whatever the dollar price of gold itself does. This is a tailwind that many investors overlook.

U.S. Fed rate and gold
Gold has an inverse relationship with the U.S. dollar (USD). When the USD strengthens, gold in dollar terms tends to soften and vice versa. The U.S. Federal Reserve is likely to raise interest rates which will act as a headwind for gold.

However, there is a limit to how much the Fed can hike as the U.S. is sitting on a huge pile of debt and higher rates mean higher cost of servicing it. At some point, the arithmetic of debt servicing and growth of economy forces a pause/reversal, in the rate cycle. Investors should see dollar-gold relationship as cyclical on gold's prospects.

Several routes
There are several routes to gold. Sovereign Gold Bonds, offering 2.5% an-

nual interest on top of gold's price appreciation are no longer issued afresh but existing bonds can be bought and sold in the secondary market. Gold Exchange Traded Funds are an evergreen option - you need a demat and trading account with a broker and can buy/sell units. If you do not have a demat account, Gold Funds from mutual funds (MFs) serve the same purpose and you can invest via regular MF folio, including SIP.

More recently, a new avenue has opened up: Electronic Gold Receipts or EGRs. These are SEBI-regulated securities representing direct ownership of physical gold held in accredited vaults. You buy/sell EGRs on the stock exchange, just like a share and they sit in demat account. Each EGR is a receipt against a specific quantity of physical gold with the option to convert holdings into gold bars/coins via withdrawal request subject to charges/taxes. EGRs are available in small denominations making them accessible even to small investors. For those who want transparency of exchange-based pricing along with the comfort of an actual claim on physical gold, EGRs are worth considering as part of the 10% allocation. Whichever route, the underlying point is: gold is not a speculative add-on, it is a structural building block of a well-constructed portfolio.

(Joydeep Sen is a corporate trainer (financial markets) and author)

When age matters

THINKINVESTOR

Are you interested in earning a dividend income? Should source of returns matter? The answer is your age determines preference for source of returns, especially via equity investments

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

In recent times, several stocks have traded at prices that offer good dividend yield. This leads to the question: Are individuals interested in earning a dividend income? Should source of returns matter? Here, we discuss how your age determines your preference for source of returns, especially from equity investments.

Income vs. capital appreciation
Equity investments, like bonds and real estate, offer two sources of returns - income returns and capital appreciation. Income returns arise from dividends received from the firm whose stocks you directly hold. You can also earn dividend income indirectly via net asset value if you invest in mutual funds. Note, this dividend income is reinvested and realised as capital appreciation if you invest in the growth option of a fund.

The choice of returns depends on age. If you are a working executive, your main objective is to accumulate wealth to achieve life goals such as funding child's education and buying a house.

This tilts your preference towards capital appreciation and is tax efficient; you pay taxes only when you sell a stock in direct investments or when you redeem mutual fund units. Now, goal-based investments are typically held for more than 12 months. So, if you have earmarked these investments for a life goal, the gains are likely to be taxed at 12.5% above ₹1.25 lakh in a year. This is because these equity investments will be taxed as long-term capital asset.

What if you are retired? Your active income would have stopped and you now depend on passive income to meet post-retirement expenses.

This means you need monthly income to support lifestyle expenses. Also, most mass-affluent retirees are conservative investors viz. they prefer to conserve capital and consume income. In such cases, they prefer to invest in monthly income bank deposits. Investing in dividend yield stocks may be preferred by some as an additional source of income.

Conclusion
If taxes were the only consideration, then earning dividend income may not be an economical source of returns.

This is because dividend income is taxed at your marginal tax rate. Yet, retirees may prefer dividend as a supplement to their interest income to meet their post-retirement expenses.

In such cases, think of taxes as the cost retirees are willing to incur to consume income without drawing down their investment capital - selling shares or mutual fund units to generate cash flows.

(The author offers training programs for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Axis Bank	8.90 onwards	10,355 onwards	2,071 onwards	Up to 2%
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.50	10,624-16,177	2,125-3,235	Up to 4.13%
Bank of Baroda*	10.15-18.00	10,660-12,697	2,132-2,539	Up to 2% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Bank of India	10.85-16.15	10,834-12,199	2,167-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Bank of Maharashtra	9.75-15.00	10,562-11,895	2,112-2,379	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Canara Bank	9.70-15.15	10,550-11,934	2,110-2,387	0.25% (Rs. 500 - Rs. 2,500)
Central Bank of India	11.25 onwards	10,934 onwards	2,187 onwards	Up to 1%
Federal Bank	11.75 - 18.99	11,059 - 12,968	2,212 - 2,594	Up to 3%
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
HSBC Bank	9.70 onwards	10,562 onwards	2,112 onwards	Up to 1%
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 3.5%
Indian Overseas Bank	10.25 onwards	10,685 onwards	2,137 onwards	Up to 0.75%
IndusInd Bank	10.49 onwards	10,744 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 3.5% (2% for instant personal loans for limited period)
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Poonawalla Fincorp	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 4%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.65-13.90	10,538-11,608	2,108-2,322	0.50%-1%
Punjab National Bank	10.25-16.80	10,685-12,373	2,137-2,475	Up to 1%
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	Up to 1.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Flat Rs. 49
UCO Bank	9.95 - 13.20	10,611-11,428	2,122-2,286	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
Union Bank of India	8.90 - 12.65	10,355-11,287	2,071-2,257	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)

*Interest concession of 0.10% to customers opting for group credit life insurance.

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Bank of Baroda	7.60 - 11.35	10,043 - 10,959	Up to Rs. 2,000
Bank of India	7.60-12.55	10,043 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
Bank of Maharashtra*	7.45-11.75	10,007 - 11,059	NIL (Limited Period Monsoon Offer)
Canara Bank**	7.45-11.45	10,007 - 10,984	0.25% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)
Central Bank of India	7.50-9.30	10,019 - 10,452	NIL (Till 31.12.2026)
HDFC Bank	8.15 onwards	10,174 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
ICICI Bank	8.40 onwards	10,234 onwards	Up to Rs. 8,500
IDFC FIRST Bank	8.99 onwards	10,377 onwards	Up to Rs. 10,000
Indian Bank	7.50-9.65	10,019 - 10,513	Rs. 1,200
Indian Overseas Bank	7.55-12.00	10,031 - 11,122	NIL
Karnataka Bank	8.13-11.63	10,169 - 11,029	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Punjab and Sind Bank***	7.55-14.05	10,031 - 11,647	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Punjab National Bank	7.60-10.70	10,043 - 10,797	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
State Bank of India	8.70 - 9.85	10,307 - 10,587	Rs. 500 - Rs. 2,000
UCO Bank	7.35-10.00	9,983 - 10,624	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
Union Bank of India	7.50-10.00	10,019 - 10,684	Up to Rs 1,000

*0.25% interest rate concession for existing home loan borrowers and other existing customers having at least 6 months of relationship with the bank.

**50% waiver on processing fee till September 30

***Concession of up to 50% on processing fee for PSB Apna Vahan Sugam.

Rates and charges as on August 26

Source: Paisabazaar.com

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.

Diaspora to shape India's next growth chapter



New India: overseas Indians are turning into long-term participants in native's growth story. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

OPINION

Sanjay Agarwal

India's next growth chapter will be driven not just by domestic demand, manufacturing and digitalisation. It will also be shaped by one of the country's most influential and underutilised assets: its global diaspora. Beyond remittances and emotional ties, overseas Indians – currently numbering 35-plus million – are turning into long-term participants in their native land's growth story.

Largest remittance recipient

India remains the world's largest recipient of remittances, with inflows of \$143.6 billion in FY26. These flows have supported millions of households, strengthened the country's external sector, and created enduring links with its diaspora. However, the coming decade may mark a more significant transition – from remittances to long-term growth capital. Increasingly, non-resident Indians (NRIs) are looking at India not only as home but also one of the world's most compelling long-term investment destinations. This reflects a growing confidence in the country's economic fundamentals and institutional maturity. It paves the way for global Indian capital to become a meaningful participant in the country's

Investment case

Although the world's sixth-largest economy in dollar terms, India remains the fastest-growing major economy, supported by robust domestic demand, an expanding manufacturing base, rapid infrastructure development and a vibrant digital economy. Macroeconomic fundamentals have also strengthened considerably. Foreign exchange reserves remain strong at over \$700 billion, providing resilience against external shocks. Inflation remains well managed, fiscal consolidation continues, and the banking system is stronger, cleaner and better capitalised than it was a decade ago. Equally important has been the consistency of reform. GST, the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, production-linked incentive schemes, digital public infrastructure and sustained investment in connectivity have helped build a more formal, productive and competitive economy. Additionally, global supply chains are diversifying and manufacturing investment is expanding. India's young demographic provides a long runway for expansion. Many overseas Indians are showing a growing interest in the capital markets, startups, alternative assets, infrastructure and wealth management solutions on offer in the country of their origin.

Mature markets

Given the growing interest from overseas Indians, the country must continue simplifying their investment journey. Perceptions around regulatory complexity, taxation, documentation requirements and cross-border investment processes remain barriers. Continued efforts towards transparency, ease of investing and digital enablement can further unlock the immense potential of global Indian capital. The country's financial ecosystem has, meanwhile, matured significantly. Equity market capitalisation reached \$5.18 trillion in July this year, retaining its position among the largest equity markets globally. Mutual fund assets under management expanded to ₹85.76 lakh crore, with monthly SIP contributions reaching a record ₹31,961 crore during the month. Historically, investments by overseas Indians were concentrated in real estate, gold or bank deposits. Today, the opportunity spans equities, debt markets, REITs, infrastructure investment trusts, alternative investment funds, manufacturing, renewable energy, and the growing innovation ecosystem.

Digital access

Institutions such as the RBI, SEBI and IFSCA have strengthened governance standards, transparency and market integrity, while the development of GIFT IFSC is creating a globally competitive financial platform within India. Simplified digital onboarding, electronic KYC and progressive reforms have made investing in India far more seamless for global investors. Digital public infrastructure, including Aadhaar, UPI, DigiLocker and Account Aggregator framework, transformed access and financial participation. *(The writer is the founder, MD and CEO of AU Small Finance Bank)*

The dynamics of talent migration whether parochial or practical?

Is an emotional appeal to return home enough for challenger States to attract talent and enterprises? In India, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Gurugram, Pune, Chennai, and Mumbai are 6 big cities when it comes to top white-collar jobs but urban planning has not kept pace with employment growth

OPINION

Kamal Karanth

‘Take me home, country roads’ by John Denver is one of my favourite numbers and I loved playing that on loop while driving to my picturesque hometown, Udupi, 400 km away from the noise and bustle of Bengaluru.

The nostalgia of growing up there eventually pushed me to set up an office in that town. However, when some of my colleagues started telling me they wanted to be in Bengaluru for their next career journey, I asked myself what had I done. Despite Bengaluru's crumbling infrastructure and crawling traffic, the younger generation appeared keen to move to the megapolis.

Workplace and worker

Big cities around the world have continuously attracted the best talent from other cities and countries, thanks to attractive career opportunities. New York, San Francisco, Singapore, and London are sought-after cities to migrate for work. In India, Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Gurugram, Pune, Chennai, and Mumbai are the six big cities when it comes to top white-collar jobs. In the last few years, however, other State capitals have tried to break the strangle-



Falling short: Urban planning in Big 6 hasn't kept pace with employment growth. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

hold of the 'Big 6' by enticing enterprises with a plethora of incentives. It's a welcome trend, as urban planning in the Big 6 hasn't kept pace with employment growth. But, I am not sure whether free benefits are enough to attract MNCs, which look at several other factors too when deciding on a location.

Talent density, Grade A real estate, and travel connectivity are the top three criteria for MNCs entering new cities.

As for employees, the top preconditions for migrating to a new place are diverse career opportunities, and an easy commute to and from their home city. Most Indian States and tier 2 towns are still work in progress in these areas.

Nine years ago, I was at



There are 49 Indian cities with over a million population each. China has 100-plus. Can these 49 cities focus on developing physical, social, and educational infrastructure?

a promotional event of a prominent State that wanted to become the next big IT hub. The first slide in the presentation by a bureaucrat was a photo of a Bengaluru traffic jam. On another occasion, I saw an industry acquaintance joking about Delhi pollution even as he promoted his State's low AQI. Sometimes people trying to lure talent or companies away from

cities like Bengaluru or Delhi forget a smear campaign against those cities are not enough. If the challenger towns don't have a compelling story of their own, they have lost even before they have begun.

Emotional appeals

Every State or tier 2 city trying to attract investors is misled by one data point: their huge diaspora working in the six big cities. The popular belief is that these professionals will return if you appeal to their emotions. Hence, you see many catchy phrases designed to appeal to parochial sensibilities. But would you really migrate back to your hometown simply because you feel more emotionally connected to it? I doubt that feeling can outlast the

Birla versus Adani: Heavy metal face-off

Suresh P. Iyengar

First they clashed over cement. Now, the corporate rivalry between the Aditya Birla Group and Adani Group is shifting to aluminium. Hindalco Industries, the flagship metals company of the Aditya Birla Group, plans to deploy around ₹50,000 crore in capacity expansion, upstream integration and downstream value-added products, in a bid to strengthen its market position ahead of Adani Group's entry into the aluminium business.

Beyond producing more aluminium, Hindalco's bigger bet is on controlling a bigger chunk of the value chain and moving towards specialised products, since their earnings are less exposed to London Metal Exchange (LME) prices. This move is significant because Adani Enterprises has joined hands with Abu Dhabi-based natural resources investment platform International Resources Holding (IRH) to build a ₹1.08-lakh-crore integrated greenfield aluminium complex in Odisha.

The emerging contest isn't unlike the two groups' rivalry in cement with UltraTech Cement, the Birla Group flagship, having to defend its leadership through organic expansion and acquisitions, including India Cements and Kesoram Industries. Its capacity has crossed 200 million tonnes per annum and is targeted to reach around 240 mtpa by FY28.

The Adani Group entered the cement segment in 2022 with the acquisition of Ambuja Cements and ACC from Holcim, and then Sanghi Industries, Penna Cement and Orient Cement. Its capacity is now around 109 mtpa, with a target of 140 mtpa



New war: The corporate rivalry between the Aditya Birla Group and Adani Group is shifting to aluminium. REUTERS

by FY28. In the case of aluminium, scale, resource security, energy costs and vertical integration could fix competitive advantage.

Big investments

The Adani-IRH project envisages a 4-mtpa alumina refinery near bauxite mines in Rayagada district, a 2-mtpa aluminium smelter, a 4,000-MW captive power plant and a 1-mtpa downstream manufacturing park in Sundargarh district.

Spread over 7,300 acres, the two phases of the project entail mega investments of around ₹66,000 crore and ₹44,000 crore, respectively.

Bauxite is expected from Odisha Mining Corporation's Sasubahumali mines and Adani's Kutrumali and Bahalda mines. The ore will be moved via conveyor belts and rail to cut logistics costs.

Adani Enterprises has indicated that clearances could take 12-18 months, and project development about three and a half years. Hindalco is ready with a response. “They are at the announcement stage, while we are actually expanding and constructing projects on the ground,” said Satish Pai, Managing Director,

Hindalco.

In January, Hindalco announced ₹21,000 crore investment to add 3.6 lakh tonnes a year of smelting capacity at its Aditya Aluminium complex in Sambalpur. Its current cumulative aluminium smelting capacity is 13 lakh tonnes a year. Overall, Hindalco plans to invest around ₹37,000 crore in Odisha across upstream and downstream aluminium operations. “Our refinery project is about halfway through and scheduled for commissioning in December next. Our smelter expansions are also coming online next year,” Pai said.

Integration advantage

Hindalco believes its ecosystem of mining, refining, smelting, downstream manufacturing and recycling capabilities is its biggest defence against any new entrant. “We have been in this business for over 68 years and have an established base and assets to build on,” Pai said.

Hindalco has also sharpened its management structure. Kailash Pandey, formerly head of mining and the Sambalpur cluster, has been elevated as CEO of Aluminium Upstream, while Kopal Agrawal has been appointed CEO of Aluminium Downstream.

Hindalco's aluminium business is being built around two objectives: secure the upstream cost base and capture more value downstream.

Kumar Mangalam Birla, Chairman of Hindalco Industries, has pointed to the company's earlier investments of about ₹45,000 crore in Mahan Aluminium, Aditya Aluminium and Utikal Alumina as the foundation for its current expansion. “Today, Aditya, the fully integrated complex, combines upstream, downstream and recycling operations, giving a unique advantage across the value chain,” Birla said. Hindalco and its U.S.-based subsidiary Novelis are together investing around \$10 billion in organic growth – a historic high for the company.

The downstream bet

Hindalco's expansion is focused on engineered products that are high-margin and not linked to LME prices. Factors such as engineering capability, product specifications, quality, technology and long-term customer relationships can determine pricing and margins.

The company recently commissioned India's first battery-grade aluminium foil facility in Odisha at an investment of ₹4,500 crore. The plant is designed to support up to 100 GWh of lithium-ion cell manufacturing.

The 99.98% pure aluminium finds uses ranging from defence and aerospace to semiconductor manufacturing. Downstream teams work with customers on material specifications and product designs. Six innovation centres support this effort.

Electric vehicles represent a big opportunity as they each require around 120 kg of aluminium in the

realities of economics.

I asked a CXO who recently set up shop in a tier 2 city and hired his first 50 employees how easy was it to hire in a smaller city.

He said the narrative of moving back appealed to professionals in their 40s, but only when offered a significant hike. For returnees, the perks of homecoming are only second to the quality and perks of the job.

The social life

A 30-something ex-colleague returned to Bengaluru after a two-year work stint in her hometown. “I enjoyed the 10-minute commute, serene beaches, quiet life and I had more personal time. But, I also quickly realised that since there were limited competing enterprises in that town, salaries weren't growing competitively. Also, I missed the diversity of restaurants, visiting breweries, late-night partying, rock concerts and live shows of Bengaluru,” she said. The young do want an active social life and unlimited career options even if the trade-off is negotiating a crowded city.

Our ability to retain or attract Gen Z in the 22 states sans megacities will be crucial to building the next six big cities of India.

The GCC mirage

States on a talent acquisition drive are going after

global capability centres (GCCs). It's a worthwhile idea, considering the huge number of GCCs launched in India over the last three years. Another 3,000 are expected in the next few years. But, one must remember that the new GCCs are setting up in India owing to the success of their peers and competitors in the Big 6 Indian cities.

The other cities are not even under discussion as they lack scalable talent, connectivity and sophisticated infrastructure. The focus of the challenger States should instead be to attract large Indian conglomerates.

There are over 3,629 Indian companies with annual revenue exceeding ₹1,000 crore each. Wouldn't it be easier for the 22 States without megacities to meet the CEOs of these desi companies versus getting an audience with Elon Musk to set up in their State/city?

There are 49 Indian cities with over a million population each. China has 100-plus. The U.S. has only a dozen. Can these 49 cities focus on developing their physical, social, and educational infrastructure? It will take a few years, but we need to remember it took a few decades to build cities like Hyderabad and Bengaluru.

(Kamal Karanth is co-founder of specialist staffing firm Xpheno)

domestic refined copper consumption projected to rise from around 0.9 million tonnes in FY26 to 3.6 million tonnes by FY47.

Hindalco can position itself not merely as a commodity producer but also supplier of materials and components for the next phase of industrialisation. The company is already working with customers on lighter, safer and more efficient components, deploying process scientists, alloy specialists, modelling experts and design engineers on the job.

Power remains critical

Hindalco is betting on renewable power to improve its long-term cost position while reducing the carbon intensity of production. It is currently the only aluminium producer in India with round-the-clock renewable power. The company has secured 400 MW of renewable energy, supported by a gross captive renewable pipeline of more than 1.3 GW and energy storage capacity exceeding 1 GWh.

Since aluminium smelting is energy-intensive, a combination of captive power, renewable energy, resource security and integrated logistics can determine where a producer sits on the global cost curve.

This is where the contest with Adani could become interesting. Adani brings expertise in infrastructure, ports, power, logistics and large-scale project execution – suited to build an integrated aluminium chain around Odisha's mineral resources. Hindalco's objective is clear: produce competitive primary metal, but also capture more value from every tonne before it reaches the customer.

(The writer is with The Hindu businessline)



Cardiologist Ayman Alyoussef, who came to Germany from Syria, working at a clinic in Quedlinburg. AFP

In far-right German bastion, hostility to migrants deepens

Agence France-Presse
QUEDLINBURG

As a far-right election victory looms in the eastern German state of Saxony-Anhalt, many migrants are readying to pack their bags, fearful of the Alternative for Germany party (AfD) party's threatened "deportation and remigration offensive".

It is an ominous scenario for Syria-born cardiologist Ayman Alyoussef, head physician in a clinic in the town of Quedlinburg, who voiced a common sentiment: "I fear that hatred of foreigners will spread."

Mr. Alyoussef, who arrived in the country in 2014 and is now a German citizen, said he has been welcomed by patients and colleagues but sometimes faces hostility on the streets.

Many foreign-born residents share such experiences and fears. Last week, some 150 migrant-run restaurants, kiosks and barber shops in the State capital Magdeburg temporarily closed their doors to protest what they warned is an increasingly xenophobic climate. Support group the Refugee Council said many migrants had reported that talk of mass deportations had sparked growing "fear and uncertainty".

AFD top candidate Ulrich Siegmund has vowed to deport all foreigners without legal status "from minute one" in office.

Whatever happens after the election planned for September 6, the heated campaign rhetoric has already deepened "societal divisions", said Mamad Mohamad, a candidate for the left-leaning Greens party.

Economists warn that the AfD's anti-migrant campaign, aside from the human toll, would spell an economic own-goal for the small State.

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

Besides a social media post from U.S. President Donald Trump, the White House has said little about what he is calling "THE BIGGEST OIL DEAL IN WORLD HISTORY" in Venezuela.

Mr. Trump said the agreement announced on Friday would give the United States a stake in Venezuela's vast oil reserves, a step toward his goal of extracting energy from the country after American forces captured then-President Nicolas Maduro in a middle-of-the-night raid in January and brought him to New York to face federal drug trafficking charges.

Venezuela's acting President, Delcy Rodríguez, described the deal as a step toward economic recovery that will modernise the country's oil industry.

"What we are doing is for the development of the country, but above all, to serve the Venezuelan people, to provide them with more jobs, better wages, and access to public services such as water, electricity, hospitals, schools and adequate food," she said.

But the answers to many questions, including how soon the reserves could be drilled and who will pay to make it happen, were not clear. No text of any agreement has been released.

The U.S. government and an unnamed private operator in Venezuela formed a new company that was given the rights to untapped oil fields for 100 years.

A statement from Ms. Rodríguez said the deal involves the development of 17 fields with a proven potential of 65 billion barrels. It said the agreement could draw \$100 billion in investment into Venezuela's oil industry and yield over \$209 billion in taxes for Caracas.

The deal gives the United States 55% effective output of the new private company, including an ownership stake and rights to buy oil at cost. American purchases of the oil will go toward the U.S. strategic oil reserves along with the military, according to a U.S. official who spoke on the condition of anonymity.

The company would be the second largest corporate holder of proven reserves after Saudi Aramco, according to the official.

Mr. Trump says the deal will help lower gas prices for Americans. That is an important objective for the Republican President as the Iran war slows the shipping of Persian Gulf oil and keeps prices elevated months before November elections in the United States.

But experts have repeat-



Rich resource: A gas flare burns at the Cardon refinery, in Punta Cardon, Venezuela. REUTERS

edly warned that Venezuela's dilapidated oil infrastructure will take years and billions of dollars to repair.

'Not anytime soon'

The deal could be "helpful in the long run, but it's not going to do anything to change the price of gasoline at the retail station for Labor Day weekend," said Amy Myers Jaffe, director of the Energy, Climate Justice and Sustainability Lab at New York University.

Kevin Book, managing director at ClearView Energy Partners, said the oil industry is awaiting clarity on the deal's details.

Venezuela has room to increase its oil production, he said – in the past it produced more than 2.5 mil-

lion barrels a day above current levels – but investments of this scale don't happen quickly.

Some in Venezuela considered it a betrayal of what their government has stated repeatedly for decades: Venezuelan resources are for Venezuela, and leaders would not allow the U.S. government access to those resources.

At a market in eastern Caracas on Saturday, a resident said he was upset about the announcement.

"I think they're doing it to cling to power," he said of Venezuela's leaders. "It's like, 'I'm giving you a vast amount of petroleum as long as you leave me alone here in power.'"

Harvard University pro-

fessor Ricardo Hausmann, a former Venezuelan Minister, called it a "shameful deal."

"Venezuelans will not respect this illegitimate deal and no major U.S. oil company will take it seriously because they know it will not last," Mr. Hausmann said on social media., adding that Ms. Rodríguez "has no legitimacy or constitutional power to commit Venezuela to any such deal."

It is unclear whether Congress will play a role in the arrangement, but lawmakers from both parties were quick to weigh in.

Republican Senator Bernie Moreno, Ohio, said it was a historic deal that helps both countries. "If it

were up to DC Democrats, Mr. Maduro would still be in power, Venezuelan oil would be going to China at half price, and the people of Venezuela would be getting robbed by a corrupt regime," Mr. Moreno wrote on social media.

It was condemned by Democrats who said Mr. Maduro's capture was a means to this end.

Democrat Senator Tim Kaine, Virginia, said Mr. Trump was always after Venezuela's oil, branding it "corruption at epic scale."

"Will prices come down for Americans? Who knows but likely not as much as Mr. Trump has forced them up thru his idiotic Iran War," Mr. Kaine said on social media.

Many important details remain unclear, including who will cover necessary investments, the identity of the private operator and how America's stake in the company breaks down.

The U.S. will get 55% of the company's effective output, but it was not clear what portion of that comes from an ownership stake and how much comes from the right to buy oil at cost.

It also is unclear how the industry will react. Persuading big American oil companies to return to the region could prove a challenge given the political uncertainty and damaged infrastructure.

AI twist: growing backlash over data centres seeps into U.S. midterm polls

Agence France-Presse
BRAZORIA

The data centres powering America's artificial intelligence boom have become an unlikely target in November's midterm elections, as anger over rising electricity bills and noise turns Democrats as well as a growing number of Republicans against 'Big Tech'.

Candidates in at least 21 races across 18 States have aired television advertisements mentioning data centres, according to U.S. media. On the grid serving Senate battleground Ohio, as well as 12 other States, demand from data centres drove up capacity costs by \$9.3 billion in a single year, a 174% increase, according to an independent market monitor.



Close encounters: An Amazon Web Services data centre adjacent to single-family homes in Stone Ridge, Virginia. AFP

In Texas, Republican Governor Greg Abbott has frozen new projects while regulators weigh their impact on power and water supplies. It was Mr. Abbott who, not long ago, called his State the "epicentre of AI development."

In Ohio, contestant Sherrod Brown, a Demo-

crat, has run at least four ads attacking Republican Jon Husted for courting data centre investment as Lieutenant Governor.

In Michigan, the issue toppled two better-connected Democrats in a primary.

In Wisconsin, Republican gubernatorial nomi-

nee Tom Tiffany has taken to calling his Democratic opponent "Data Centre David Crowley."

Mr. Tiffany wants the State's tax incentives scrapped and the industry more tightly regulated, though he stops short of a ban. Democratic Governors are moving the same way.

New York has imposed a year-long moratorium on new hyperscale facilities, and Pennsylvania now requires developers to cover infrastructure costs.

Almost alone among Republicans, President Donald Trump has not moved. He still calls the industry essential to beating China on AI, leaving him at odds with candidates running under his own banner.

Aerial dazzle



Turkish Stars, the aerobatic demonstration team of the Turkish Air Force, perform at the annual Bucharest International Air Show that brings military aircraft and sky-high demonstrations to the Romanian capital, on Saturday. AP

New U.K. PM Burnham set to face first major test as Parliament returns

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Andy Burnham has enjoyed a honeymoon first month as U.K. Prime Minister, but the hard trade-offs involved in governing are about to get real as Parliament returns from its summer break in the coming days.

Since succeeding Keir Starmer on July 20, Mr. Burnham has pleased voters with several low-cost sweeteners, including cutting electricity bills and bus fares, while burnishing his casual man-of-the-people vibes.

He has poured pints of beer with his Finance Minister, played guitar in Ukraine, and kept up a prolific output of slick social media videos during a self-styled "listening tour" of Britain.

Mr. Burnham has sparked a poll bounce for his ruling Labour Party.

A YouGov survey published on August 18 found that 46% of Britons view him favourably, up 12 percentage points from when he first arrived at Downing Street.

With lawmakers on holiday, the new Prime Minister has largely been able to avoid thornier issues during his first weeks in office.

"He's benefited enormously from Parliament not being there," former senior civil servant Jill Rutter said, adding that it had allowed Mr. Burnham to "control the narrative" so far.

MPs return to Westminster on Tuesday, when Mr. Burnham is expected to deliver his first speech to Parliament as Prime Minister. His government will

detail a watering down of contentious plans to release thousands of prisoners early to ease chronic overcrowding in jails.

Mr. Burnham said on Sunday that hundreds of more serious offenders will remain behind bars, but conceded he was pushing the prison system to "the very limits of what's possible without risking... (it)... collapsing within months".

Then on Wednesday, MPs and the public will learn whether Mr. Burnham is any good at facing down the weekly grilling by the Leader of the Opposition when he takes part in his first Prime Minister's Questions session.

Budget issues

Looming on the horizon is his government's first budget on October 28, when Mr. Burnham must demon-



Summer break: Andy Burnham plays the guitar in Ukraine's capital Kyiv during his first trip abroad since taking office. REUTERS

strate that he can fund his pledges regarding cost-of-living support and ending rough sleeping, all while plugging a huge gap in defence spending.

He must do so against a backdrop of strained public finances and with limited levers to pull due to his commitment not to raise income tax, em-

pLOYEE payroll contributions, or a value-added tax on consumer goods.

"That might be when reality starts to hit," said former Minister Tony McNulty, who served alongside Mr. Burnham in Labour governments of the early 2000s.

Mr. McNulty, now a politics lecturer at Queen Ma-

ry University of London, insists Mr. Burnham is capable of taking tough decisions and "sticking" to them, despite opponents labelling him a "people pleaser".

Plenty of sensitive issues lie ahead, including welfare reform, how to fund social care, and whether to proceed with the scrapping of jury trials for many offences.

Whether to extract oil and gas at the controversial Jackdaw and Rosebank fields in the North Sea could be one of the most divisive questions.

"You either alienate the unions by saying no and get noises off from (U.S. President) Donald Trump in a very unhelpful way," explained Ms. Rutter. "Or Mr. Burnham gives drilling a green light and you alienate the Labour net zero

(supporters) who say we're going to lose more support to the Greens".

Ties with EU

Mr. Burnham will host his first European leader since taking office when French President Emmanuel Macron visits London this week.

It comes as he must decide how to proceed with a "reset" with the European bloc that was championed by Mr. Starmer ahead of a bilateral summit expected this year.

Mr. Burnham has said Britain must be "bolder" in getting closer to the bloc, but has ruled out rejoining the single market, customs union or allowing freedom of movement.

"The EU isn't handing out sweets just because we've got a sort of fun Prime Minister who likes

(1980s English rock band) The Smiths," added Ms. Rutter.

A likely first meeting with Mr. Trump, possibly at the United Nations General Assembly next month, will be tricky for Mr. Burnham who once described the U.S. President's policies as "poisonous".

Labour lawmaker Jess Phillips said on a Sky News podcast last week that Mr. Burnham must "show what his actual priorities are" but in doing so runs the risk of disappointing many MPs.

MP Luke Akehurst said that Mr. Burnham's positive start "gives him a significant bank of political capital" among Labour colleagues "who will need to trust his judgment in addressing the range of complex policy issues that the government faces".

INBRIEF



Abhay Singh wins 13th PSA Tour title in Malaysia

Top seed Abhay Singh clinched the Tuanku Muhriz Trophy squash, a \$15,000 PSA Challenger event in Negeri Sembilan, Malaysia on Sunday, defeating third seed Henry Leung of Hong Kong 11-7, 6-11, 3-11, 11-5, 12-10 to bag his 13th PSA Tour title in 18 finals. Abhay beat the Malaysian trio of Ameeshenraj Chandaran 7-11, 11-9, 11-7, 7-11, 11-3 in the semifinals, Md. Syafiq Kamal 11-4, 11-13, 11-5, 11-5 in the quarterfinals and Low Wa Sern 8-11, 11-2, 11-6, 11-2 in the second round following a first-round bye.



Chennai Bulls dominates the opening day of the ECL

Chennai Bulls, representing Tamil Nadu, proved its dominance by leading the team and overall standings on day one of the National-level Equestrian Champions League (ECL) at an arena near the Equestrian Crest in Molapalayam near Coimbatore on Saturday.

Team standings (100 cms & 110 cms): 1. Chennai Bulls (Tamil Nadu) 115 points, 2. Golconda Chargers (Telangana) 72, 3. Elite Equestrians (West Bengal) 63.
120 cms: 1. Pegasus Sports (Kerala) 50, Elite Equestrians 45, Bangalore Knights (Karnataka) 40.
Overall: 1. Chennai Bulls 180, 2. Golconda Chargers 121, 3. Pegasus Sports 111.

Chelsea signs Emiliano Martinez from Villa

Argentina’s 2022 World Cup-winning goalkeeper Emiliano Martinez has joined Chelsea from fellow Premier League outfit Aston Villa. The 33-year-old has signed a three-year contract with Chelsea, following a deal worth £7.5 million, according to British media. Martinez returns to London, where he began his professional career with Arsenal.

LIVE TELECAST

Duleep Trophy: Day 2, JioHotstar, 9.30 a.m.
W20I tri-series: Namibia vs Zimbabwe, FanCode, 5.30 p.m.
Women’s T20 Asia Cup: Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 8 p.m.
US Open: SS Select 1, 2 & JioHotstar, 8.30 p.m. & 4.30 a.m. (Tuesday)
Serie A: Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & Z5 App, 10 p.m. & 12.15 a.m. (Tuesday)
LaLiga: FanCode, 11 p.m. & 1 a.m. (Tuesday)
Premier League: SS Select 1 & JioHotstar, 12.30 a.m. (Tuesday)



Nabi. ANI

Auqib Nabi set to play three County C'ship games for Surrey

ANI
NEW DELHI

Jammu and Kashmir pacer Auqib Nabi is set to represent Surrey in the Division One County Championship fixtures from next week, with an eye on two Tests against New Zealand away from home in November. Nabi could feature in three County Championship games.

He is expected to return back home in time for India-A’s four-day fixtures against Australia-A, starting from September 22.

Rohan’s blistering knock powers Globstars to an easy win

KCL

M.R. Praveen Chandran
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

After Saturday’s one-run win over Thrissur Titans, it was a step back for Kochi Blue Tigers as it slumped to a heavy eight-wicket loss against Calicut Globstars in the KCL 2026 at the Sports Hub Greenfield stadium on Sunday.

Captain Rohan S. Kunnummal’s blistering 78 (39b, 4x4, 7x6) fired Globstars to an emphatic win and moved it to second in the table with eight points. Kochi remains at the bottom with four points.

Batting first, Tigers were pegged back by regular wickets and managed to post an under-par 150 for eight. Only Sachin Suresh (42 not out) and U. Manukrishan (30) made substantial contributions against a disciplined Globstars’ attack.

The total was never going to threaten the strong

Globstars moves to second in the table with eight points while Kochi remains at the bottom with four points
Trivandrum Royals eases past Aries Kollam Sailors by seven wickets for its third straight win

Globstars batting line-up and Rohan got into his groove early by smashing Eden Apple Tom for two sixes in the second over.

Varun Nayanar fell cheaply to left-arm spinner P.K. Midhun but new batter K.S. Aravind wrested the momentum in the last over of the PowerPlay by hitting four boundaries off left-arm spinner P.S. Jerin.

Saturday’s hero Karthik B. Nair’s first over was expensive as Rohan and Aravind plundered 20 runs to put Globstars firmly in control. The third-wicket stand between Rohan and Aravind registered 101 runs off just 53 balls and when the skipper fell to a fine catch by Mohammed Ashique at the deep square-leg fence, the fate of the match was already sealed.

Later, Trivandrum Royals eased past Aries Kollam Sailors by seven wickets for its third straight win.

Vishnu Vinod stroked an unbeaten 65 and shared an unbroken 106-run fourth-wicket stand with Sijomon Joseph (37 not out) to carry Royals to victory with 17 balls to spare.

Earlier, a disciplined bowling effort from Royals restricted Sailors to 126 for seven. N.M. Sharafuddeen (39 not out) top scored for Sailors. Royals climbed to third with eight points while Kollam slipped to fifth place with seven.

The scores: Kochi Blue Tigers 150/8 in 20 overs (Sachin Suresh 42 n.o., U. Manukrishnan 30, Abdul Basith 2/11, Akhin Sathar 2/21) lost to Calicut Globstars 151/2 in 16 overs (Rohan S. Kunnummal 78, K.S. Aravind 44 n.o.).

Aries Kollam Sailors 126/7 in 20 overs (N.M. Sharafuddeen 39 n.o., Rahul Chandran 2/19, Sijomon Joseph 2/14) lost to Trivandrum Royals 127/3 in 17.1 overs (Vishnu Vinod 65 n.o., Sijomon Joseph 37 n.o., A.G. Amal 2/19).



Under a cloud: The squad’s abysmal World Cup campaign has raised many questions. PTI

Yamal is getting back to his top level, says Flick

FOOTBALL

Agence France-Presse
BARCELONA

Barcelona manager Hansi Flick felt that teenage star Lamine Yamal was finding the way back to his “top level”. He was speaking ahead of Monday’s LaLiga clash against Rayo Vallecano.

The 19-year-old struggled in Barcelona’s first match of the season at Elche but improved against Athletic Bilbao albeit without finding the net. Flick said that the Spanish World Cup winner was returning to his best, which Yamal has not hit since suffering a hamstring injury in April.

The winger returned at the World Cup but had limited individual impact at the tournament. “I know everyone is worried about how Lamine is and how he



Stepping on the gas: Yamal will be eager to open his account in the match against Rayo. AFP

is doing. Look at his situation... he played a World Cup after a huge injury,” Flick said.

“Now he is coming back after a three-week holiday. The first game maybe was not his best. But as I said earlier, I was happy that he started the game and worked for the team. He played 90 minutes against

Bilbao. And for him at the moment, it is good to [have] 90 minutes on the pitch.

“We saw him at his top level in some situations. You could not see it in the training session today, but I saw it and it was excellent. Everyone loves Lamine. We have to support him and we do that.”

HOCKEY

Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

With the Indian men’s hockey team returning a disappointing performance at the recent World Cup, questions have already been raised over coach Craig Fulton’s role and the continuation of several senior players in the side.

But what has gone unnoticed is the role of selectors; specifically, the ones who selected the team. However, questioning the selectors is easier said than done, given the complete opacity around Hockey India’s selection committee and its workings.

According to the Hockey India website itself, there are 16 selectors that take turns for selection duty besides the chief coaches, scientific advisors / doctors / physiotherapists and the High Performance Director. In reality, the same people have been going around for years.

Consider this: Yuvraj Walmiki and Chinglensana Singh Kangujam, the youngest of the lot, have not been informed or invited for selection duties for almost two years.

Rajnish Mishra hasn’t been called since 2024 either, as has Sameer Dad. M.M. Somaya had already written earlier this year requesting to be removed as a selector after being repeatedly ignored.

Sardar Singh and Rani Rampal, as chief coaches of the men’s and women’s national sub-junior sides respectively, have remained wrapped up with team duties. Mishra too has been entrusted Under-18 coaching duties along with Sardar. Asunta Lakra has been sidelined.

The post of High Performance Director has been vacant since September 2024, when Dutchman Herman Kruis’s six-month tenure got over.

On the other hand, BP Govinda, Balwinder Singh and Mohd. Riaz besides RP Singh in his role as the chairman travel everywh-

ere. “I wasn’t called for selection duties for almost two years. Only when I myself called up to suggest that I travel from Mumbai for the junior women’s Nationals recently in Pune on my own was I told that I had been, in fact, already removed as a selector,” Walmiki confirmed to *The Hindu*.

As per the Hockey India constitution, selectors are appointed and removed by the executive committee. In reality, the EC is hardly ever consulted.

“The executive board has been completely bypassed for everything. It is frankly frustrating,” EC member Asima Ali admitted.

“Many of the younger selectors had suggested putting a plan in place even before Paris, knowing that it could be the end for some senior players. But HI and the chief coach overruled everyone who opposed. Over time, we have not been called up even for domestic competitions,” one selector alleged.

Emmanuel’s noble work for a ‘Bright’ football future in Rwanda

S. Shrivathsan
CHENNAI

For 120-odd football-mad kids at Kigali in Rwanda, Chennaiyin FC’s new signing Emmanuel Imanishimwe is the “president”. Wonder why?

The Rwanda international is a co-founder of the football school where the children are having a ball. In a bid for a better tomorrow, Emmanuel had set up the Bright Football Academy in the company of former National-team colleague Dany Usengimana.

The kids handpicked via trials in the capital city receive training, clothing and equipment for free while those who enrol themselves at the centre on their own are charged a nominal fee. It is all about “giving back” to the beautiful game for the 31-year-old. “The person who coached me when I was young (Eric Habimana) is now heading our academy.



Positive outlook: Emmanuel is set for his maiden ISL season and is confident that CFC will do well. CHENNAIYIN FC

I wanted to do something for him... I want the youngsters to be successful. That is why I am doing everything I can,” Emmanuel, set for his maiden Indian Super League, told *The Hindu*.

“We select players from Kigali to come to our academy. Our sponsors and well-wishers have also contributed to this journey. We want to make it a bigger project in the future. It is not easy in terms of fund-

ing, but we will keep trying,” he added.

Emmanuel’s magnanimity, though, does not extend to the pitch he competes on. “We, at Chennaiyin, want to win something. I feel that we will do something. We have good players and we are going to fight.”

A ‘Bright’ beginning in Indian football is what the versatile defender is aiming for.



Marquez. AFP

Marc Marquez wins Aragon MotoGP

Agence France-Presse
ALCANIZ (SPAIN)

Marc Marquez claimed victory at the Aragon MotoGP on Sunday, with Pedro Acosta finishing second and Marco Bezzecchi third.

Seven-time MotoGP champion Marquez has a strong record at the MotorLand circuit and climbed to second in the overall standings behind Jorge Martin, who came fifth. It was Marquez’s fourth win of the season, all of those coming within the last six races as he reignited his title bid in spectacular fashion.

R. Kaushik

Even before November 1999, a host of exceptional wicketkeeper-batters had graced the international scene, not least India's own Farokh Engineer and the wonderful Andy Flower from Zimbabwe. But from the time a left-hander from Western Australia stormed the Test firmament at the Gabba in Brisbane nearly 27 years back with a bruising 81 on debut, against a shell-shocked Pakistani outfit, wicketkeeper-batters have been looked at in an entirely different vein.

Adam Gilchrist rewrote the dynamics of Test batsmanship. He was a destructive opener in limited-overs cricket long before he played his first Test, and reeled off numerous wondrous knocks, including in the final of the 50-over 2007 World Cup when, with a squash ball for company, he bludgeoned his way to 149 against Mahela Jaywardene's Sri Lanka in a decisive effort that took Australia to a hat-trick of titles. But it was in the red-ball game that Gilchrist set stall as a pioneer, providing not just meaningful heft to the Australian batting but scoring runs at such a furious clip that opponents were often ducking, unsuccessfully, for cover.

For the most part of his glittering career that encompassed 96 Tests, the left-hander had the luxury of batting behind a grand top six that used different methodologies to subjugate bowling attacks in all parts of the world. The sight of Gilchrist, the destroyer supreme, striding in purposefully at No. 7, was dispiriting or exhilarating, depending on which side of the fence one was. Gilchrist seldom disappointed; when he scored his runs, he did so with not just panache and chutzpah but also with a violent streak that damaged bowling figures as well as egos. How could anyone bat with such unchecked aggression at No. 7? How could someone fuse a no-holds-barred approach with such consistency (as an average of 47.60 at a strike-rate of 81.95 will unequivocally testify to)?

Gold standard
Gilchrist will remain the gold standard among wicketkeeper-batters, the platform from which the likes of Mahendra Singh Dhoni, more than anyone else, launched himself into the stratosphere. Gilchrist's towering presence kept an entire

generation - or more - of Aussie stumper-batters out of international reckoning. India, however, found a judicious balance; while Dhoni's aggression in front of the stumps and his brilliance behind it precluded a dynamic new force breaking through, India were

compelled to find a place, if only as a specialist batter, for Dinesh Karthik, the ebullient little right-hander from Chennai who was more than good enough to hold his own as a batter.

Karthik wasn't the first Indian gloveman to play as a specialist batter. Nearly four decades before him, Budhi Kunderan donned that role, even opening the batting in England in 1967 alongside designated wicketkeeper Engineer. A couple of decades on, Chandrakant Pandit played as a middle-order bat with Kiran More slotting in as the wicketkeeper. Such was Karthik's great natural ability - which he didn't maximise, he will acknowledge - that in the Dhoni era, India fielded him as a full-fledged opener overseas, and with no little success. Alongside Wasim Jaffer, Karthik formed an excellent opening combine in Bangladesh and England in 2007, bringing up his only Test ton across the border and bettering that effort by emerging as India's highest scorer in England, when they last won a Test series there by a slender 1-0 margin.

Karthik played his last eight Tests down the order, sometimes when Dhoni wasn't available (including through retirement) and he donned the big gloves, and at others when he played alongside the Jharkhandi as a pure batter. Just one half-century in his last 14 Test innings meant he played the last of his 26 Tests in August 2018; his Test average of 25 was decidedly underwhelming, given his supreme gift as a batter, but that can happen when one is overeager and anxious to not just justify their selection but also state their case for a longer rope.

India now have a profusion of excellent wicketkeeper-batters across formats - Rishabh Pant, of course, tops that chart, especially when it comes to the red-ball variant, but there are a host of others that can't be ignored. Among them are Sanju Samson and Ishan Kishan, exclusive when it comes to the white-ball version. And Dhruv Jurel, the 25-year-old from Agra whose first Test cap came as a wicketkeeper against England in Rajkot in February 2024 when Pant was out after his horrific road accident of 14 months previously and KS Bharat had played himself out of the XI with poor efforts in the first two Tests in Hyderabad and Visakhapatnam respectively.

The generational talent that Pant is, he kept almost exclusively from the time he made his Test debut in Nottingham in August 2018 and made a stunning 114 in his third appearance at the Oval till his single-car accident in December 2022

Jurel — a blend of versatility and fortitude

The decision-makers continued to invest their belief in him and the batter has responded in style. Towards the end of June, he was a part of the India 'A' squad that travelled on the 'shadow' tour of Sri Lanka for two unofficial 'Tests'



AP

when India were suddenly forced to scramble for a replacement. Bharat, from Andhra, won the early nod for the home Tests against Australia in February 2023 and donned the big gloves in the final of the World Test Championship against the same opponents that June. KL Rahul was nominated the first-choice stumper for the two Tests in South Africa towards the end of the year, more to provide stability and class to the lower order in a line-up from which very few had played in South Africa previously. Bharat reclaimed his spot behind the sticks against England at home and played himself out of the XI following scores of 41, 28, 17 and 6 which meant that in seven Tests and 12 innings, he only averaged 20.09, a definite no-no given that the wicketkeeper's was no longer a single-discipline specialised slot.

Out went the call to Jurel for the third Test in Rajkot with the series finely poised at 1-1, and it was immediately apparent that India had hit upon a gold mine. The right-hander made a poised 46 on debut, and upped the ante in the next match with scores of 90 and 39 not out, the first ensuring that India didn't end up conceding a massive lead and the second taking them home in a tense run-chase when he and Shubman Gill put on 72 for the unfinished sixth-wicket stand.

This was in February 2024, when one wasn't sure when Pant would be available for selection though in a characteristic show of gumption and guts, the stocky left-hander was far ahead of the timelines the doctors had tentatively outlined for a possible comeback to competitive cricket. Pant was ready for international cricket in September that year, making a remarkable recovery from a series of potentially life-threatening injuries to smash 109 on his comeback Test in Chennai against Bangladesh. Suddenly, Jurel faced an uncertain future. Despite an impressive start to his Test career, he had to bow before the irrepressible force that Pant was, though it was always on the cards that he could slot in alongside Pant, if not necessarily ahead of him.

In six of his last nine Tests, Jurel has occupied a specialist batter's position between No. 4 and No. 8 (and that only

because Akash Deep was employed as a nightwatchman at the Oval last August). On the three occasions when was the designated wicketkeeper, Pant was unavailable through injury after breaking his right foot in the Manchester Test against England in July last year. Despite the vast array of batting riches at India's disposal, head coach Gautam Gambhir has identified in Jurel a dependable batting option, and the man from Uttar Pradesh has comprehensively justified that faith with two hundreds and a fifty in those nine Tests and 15 innings.

Jurel's coming-of-age moment, if it can be called that, transpired in Ahmedabad last October with Pant still to recover from the broken foot. In India's only innings against West Indies, he uncorked an excellent 125, then followed it up with 44 in the next Test in Delhi. With Pant returning to action against South Africa in November, Jurel continued on as a batter alone though like the rest of his colleagues, he had a series to forget with outings of 14, 13, 0 and 2 in a disastrous 0-2 result that has comprehensively dented India's hopes of making a third WTC final in four cycles.

But instead of pressing the panic button and looking elsewhere, the decision-makers continued to invest their belief in him and Jurel has responded in style. Towards the end of June, he was a part of the India 'A' squad that travelled on the 'shadow' tour of Sri Lanka for two unofficial 'Tests', ostensibly at the insistence of Gambhir because of his felicity against the turning ball. Jurel warmed up nicely for the Test series to follow with scores of 141 not out, 14 and 53, and it was no surprise that he was picked for the first Test in Galle, when he weighed in with 51 and 7 in a winning cause.

In Colombo last week, Jurel went one better with an unbeaten 115 during which he brought his technical expertise and his mental fortitude into play. He also kept wickets for a while when Pant was recovering from a blow to his right shoulder sustained while batting, and when he went back to the outfield, took a terrific running catch from point to get rid of Lahiru Kumara in Sri Lanka's first

innings. At every stage in every role, he has looked the part, making his presence felt with total commitment and a never-say-die spirit without seeking recourse to the flashy and the flamboyant.

Jurel was chosen for Sri Lanka for his ability to play spin with finesse, and it is hard now to see him being overlooked during the November Test tour of New Zealand where the challenges for batters will be vastly different. At No. 6, behind Pant, he has the technique to tackle the second new ball if that is what he is confronted with. Ravindra Jadeja behind him in the batting order and the possible return of Washington Sundar from injury mean he is a right-handed option around a plethora of left-handers, and while that alone can't be a qualification, he has shown that he can hold his own against bowling of any kind in any conditions.

India are fortunate that in Jurel, they have a three-in-one cricketer with his entire future ahead of him. As a batting average of 40.68 from 12 Tests proves, he is every bit

THE GIST

Jurel's coming-of-age moment, if it can be called that, transpired in Ahmedabad last October with Pant still to recover from the broken foot. In India's only innings against West Indies, he uncorked an excellent 125, then followed it up with 44 in the next Test in Delhi

In Colombo last week, Jurel went one better with an unbeaten 115 during which he brought his technical expertise and mental fortitude into play. At every stage in every role, he has looked the part, making his presence felt with total commitment and a never-say-die spirit without seeking recourse to the flashy and the flamboyant

As a batting average of 40.68 from 12 Tests proves, he deserves the show of confidence. A place in the starting XI in Wellington in November is no more than he deserves. One can rest assured that Jurel will be short on neither preparation nor fire

deserving of the show of confidence. A place in the starting XI in Wellington in November is no more than he deserves; one can rest assured that Jurel will be short on neither preparation nor fire when 'Play' is called at the Basin Reserve.



GETTY IMAGES

TAMIL NADU



Convenience compromised: Passengers find it rather painful walking to the car park to board cabs at the Meenambakkam airport where phase 2 modernisation continues. Amenities here are not at all comparable to those at the airports in Bengaluru and Hyderabad. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

Grounded until take-off

With the Parandur airport now a closed chapter, Tamil Nadu has to press ahead with another alternative, viable site for Chennai's second airport. **Sunitha Sekar** takes a look at the options that are available to the State and processes involved in establishing a new airport. Cheyyur in Chengalpattu district and Gummidipoondi in Tiruvallur district are top contenders for Chennai's second airport

Nearly three decades after the idea to build a second airport for Chennai was first mooted, the Tamil Nadu government finds itself at the drawing board again, hunting for a fresh site, after the Tamilaga Vetti Kazhagam (TVK) government cancelled the Parandur airport project.

Cheyyur and Gummidipoondi were among the 11 locations originally considered when the search for the second airport project began nearly seven to eight years ago. At the moment, it is not clear why these two locations had never made it to the shortlist of four sites – Parandur, Pannur, Thiruporur, and Padalam. Though discussions had been held on Pannur too, it is not clear if it is still in the race.

Cheyyur airspace under IAF

Sources say that if the Cheyyur site is pursued, the State government may have to get the approval of the Ministry of Defence since the site could fall within the airspace controlled by the Indian Air Force, Tambaram. At Gummidipoondi, the Pulicat Lake is closer to the site, and it remains to be seen how bird movement will affect air traffic. “No decision has yet been taken on the site. The State government will take a decision soon,” a source says. It is learnt that a site inspection is expected to happen anytime.

After finalising the site, the government must request the Airports Authority of India (AAI) to do the pre-feasibility study and give its recommendation. Subsequently, roping in a consultant and applying for the site clearance will start afresh.

After the Sriperumbudur airport project proposed in the mid-2000s was aborted, Parandur came the closest to hosting Chennai's second airport. Now, all the procedures for building a second airport must begin from scratch.

For the second airport project planned at Parandur in Kancheepuram district on 5,846 acres, the government had completed the acquisition of 1,802 acres, which Industries Minister Keerthana said would be used for industrial purposes.

Enhancing capacity at Meenambakkam

Since building an airport at any chosen site will take a minimum of five to seven years, the State government has shifted its immediate focus to enhancing the capacity of the existing airport at Meenambakkam by constructing T5 Terminal (near the remote bays and between the main and secondary runways). With the completion of phase 2 modernisation (building of T2 and T3 Terminals), the airport's capacity will increase to 35 million passengers a year and the handling capacity will further be expanded to 55 million passengers a year on the completion of T5 Terminal. An elevated corridor from National Highway 32 needs to be constructed to enable air passengers to enter T5 Terminal.

But air passengers and aviation experts say a few projects being carried out by the AAI are already reeling under delays. For instance, phase 2 modernisation's original deadline was 2022. But it is yet to be completed.



An airport is far more than a piece of transport infrastructure; for a capital city and economic powerhouse like Chennai, it is a strategic enabler of economic growth, global competitiveness, trade, tourism, investment, and job creation

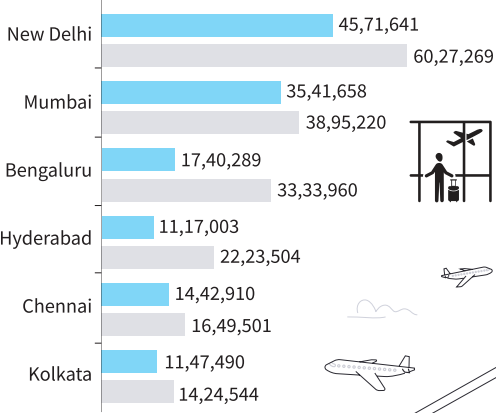
RAVICHANDRAN PURUSHOTHAMAN, chairman, CII Southern Region

Losing lustre

Aviation experts underscore the need for a second airport to boost Chennai's aircraft and cargo movement. From the third position in passenger traffic nationwide, the Chennai airport has been pushed to the fifth spot, with insufficient amenities.

TOTAL PASSENGER TRAFFIC

■ June 2016 ■ July 2026



Constructing the elevated corridor and the terminal will take years, an aviation expert says. He points out that a detailed project report needs to be prepared for T5 Terminal and the elevated corridor. “To fix the designs, call for bids, and then complete the entire process, it could take a minimum of five years, provided the AAI meets all the deadlines and the project is carried out at a meticulous pace,” he adds.

‘Facilities better at Bengaluru, Hyderabad’

Sandhya Vedullapalli, a frequent flyer, says she has encountered a few issues at the Chennai airport. “It is painful to walk to the multi-level car park to board the cab. For years together, they have been modernising the airport and building an integrated terminal, and this is putting so many people to inconvenience. It is not easy to push the trolley and walk outside the airport since it is not a smooth contiguous path,” she adds.

Be it the state of washrooms or the number of dining and shopping options, everything is so much better at the Bengaluru and Hyderabad airports, Ms. Vedullapalli says, adding that if the second airport had been built at Sriperumbudur by now, air passengers wouldn't be suffering. “There should be policy continuity. One government proposes it, then another drops it. Until another airport is built, it is the air passengers who will have to put up with various issues, and it is unfair,” she adds.

The government should soon find a site to address the development needs of the city even while balancing the environmental concerns.

A. Sankar, another frequent flyer, says Chennai has lost out on adding direct flights to many destinations, while Bengaluru seems to have

Delays in completion of projects at Chennai airport

Second cab pick-up point was ready in December 2025. But it hasn't been opened to passengers. Delayed by nearly two years.

Refurbishment of T1 and T4 Terminals for capacity enhancement and modification of stormwater drains, too, suffer from delays.

Phase II modernisation, which included building an integrated terminal, should have been completed in 2022. T2 Terminal was launched in 2023, T3 Terminal is still under construction and faces repeated delays. The next deadline is December 2026.

Issues that need to be addressed

- 1 Enhancing overall maintenance
- 2 Shifting of cab pick-up point
- 3 Improving wayfinding outside the terminals
- 4 Improving the quality and maintenance of rest rooms
- 5 Increasing the number of retail outlets in multi-level car parking
- 6 Aggressive marketing to draw more airlines and enhance connectivity

Source: Airports Authority of India

grabbed them in time. Earlier, there were direct flights to Paris and Tokyo, but they are no longer available from Chennai. Meanwhile, Bengaluru now boasts direct flights to Tokyo, Paris, Amsterdam, Vietnam, and the Maldives. “Chennai really needs direct flights to many European destinations, and initiatives have to be taken,” he adds.

Industry leaders have reiterated the need for state-of-the-art airport infrastructure as it will not only help in drawing more airlines and connecting the city directly to more domestic and international destinations but will also drive up the economy. The ‘Aerotropolis’ model, which is fast emerging now, revolves around airport-led development wherein businesses, commercial complexes, residential communities, and the logistics industry come up in the airport's vicinity. Ravichandran Purushothaman, chairman of Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) Southern Region, summed it up rather well: “An airport is far more than a piece of transport infrastructure; for a capital city and economic powerhouse like Chennai, it is a strategic enabler of economic growth, global competitiveness, trade, tourism, investment, and job creation.”

Choose a site quickly: CII

The CII notes in a statement that while modernising the Meenambakkam airport is essential, it is only a medium-term plan for the city. “Choosing a site [for the second airport] quickly is critical and once it is done, the project should be expedited and executed with urgency to ensure Chennai retains its competitive advantage among India's leading industrial and investment destinations.”

Vijay Gopalan, former chief financial officer of

AirAsia India, says the decision to scrap the Parandur airport project will prove to be a costly mistake, pushing Chennai's growth behind by at least 10 years. While the government claims that an airport alone will not decide investments, what it fails to acknowledge is that such decisions reflect poorly on a city's image, he says. “The perceptions matter so much when you have to attract young talent. While I'm glad the government is finally waking up to the need for setting up more Global Capability Centres (GCCs) for young talent and delegates to choose the city, we need better social infrastructure, and of course a good airport. A world-class airport substantially boosts the image of a city and its branding. The faster we understand this, the better it is for the city. Else, we will stagnate while Bengaluru and

After the Sriperumbudur airport project proposed in the mid-2000s was aborted, Parandur came the closest to hosting Chennai's second airport. Now, all the procedures for building a second airport must begin from scratch

Hyderabad grow at a phenomenal pace,” he says.

Chennai's primary competitive advantage lies in its robust manufacturing ecosystem, which continues to attract substantial global investments into Tamil Nadu, says Dinesh K. Krishnan, national treasurer, The Air Cargo Agents Association of India. “However, the current handling of air cargo fails to match this industrial momentum, falling significantly short of the operational efficiency delivered by privately managed airports in Bengaluru and Hyderabad,” he says.

‘Improve utilisation’

There is also an argument in a few quarters on whether Tamil Nadu needs a new international airport. Uvakai Research Foundation, in its recent report, says there is scope to improve the utilisation of the existing airport before going in for another major airport. But aviation experts point out that unless a newly built second airport run by a private operator is established, Chennai's aircraft and cargo movement cannot increase significantly. From the third position in passenger traffic, Chennai has been pushed to the fifth spot. “The Bengaluru and Hyderabad airports are growing remarkably because of their efficiency,” an expert says.

Mr. Krishnan adds that today, trade logistics face severe operational bottlenecks, and exporters and freight agents frequently complete customs clearance in Chennai, only to transport their cargo by bonded trucks to the Bengaluru airport. “This detour is driven by Bengaluru's faster cargo processing, lower air freight rates, and overall operational predictability,” he adds. With professionalised terminal management, the Chennai cargo facility can effectively service regional trade for another 10 to 15 years, while long-term second-airport plans materialise, he says.

People gather on Mirza Ghalib Street, Kolkata, after a fire broke out on the second floor of Florence Mansion, killing nine persons in Hotel Shikha Inn. PTI

Turned into a tinderbox

A IN-Y

